

Chapter 1

Tao called Tao is not Tao. Names can name no lasting name. Nameless: the origin of heaven and earth. Naming: the mother of ten thousand things. Empty of desire, perceive mys

There are ways but the Way is uncharted; There are names but not nature in words: Nameless indeed is the source of creation But things have a mother and she has a name. The secret waits for the insight Of eyes unclouded

Words cannot describe the Tao, and The Tao cannot be named. That which is eternal is unnameable. Naming is the basis of things. Free from desire you are a mys

Tao that can be described is not the universal and eternal Tao; Name that can be named is not the universal and eternal name. The beginning of Heaven and Earth is nameless; The mother of everything is naming. Thus: Be always objective

tery. Filled with desire, perceive manifestations. These have the same source, but different names. Call them both deep - Deep and again deep: the gateway to all mystery. up

by longing; Those who are bound by desire See only the outward container. These two come paired but distinct By their names. Of all things profound, Say that their pairing is deepest, The gate to the root of the world.

tery. Caught in desire you are known. The mystery and the known are not separate. It is naming which separates us. Only through paradox can you understand. up

, one discover the wonders; Be always subjective, one only sees the manifestations. Both emerge from the same source, but with different names. Both are mysterious. The mystery hidden inside of mysteries Is the door to all wonders. up

Chapter 2

Recognize beauty and ugliness is born. Recognize good and evil is born. Is and Isn't produce each other. Hard depends on easy, Long is tested by short, High is determined by low, Sound is harmonized by voice, After is followed by before. Therefore

Since the world points up beauty as such, There is ugliness too. If goodness is taken as goodness, Wickedness enters as well. For is and is-not come together; Hard and easy are complementary; Long and short are relative; High and low are comparative; Pitch and sound make harmony; Before and after are a sequence. Indeed the W

Beauty doesn't exist; Ugliness doesn't exist: except through the other. Good doesn't exist; bad doesn't exist: except through the other. Long doesn't exist; short doesn't exist: except through the other. High doesn't exist; low doesn't exist: except through the other. Before doesn't exist; after doesn't exist: except through the other. Inside doesn't exist; outside doesn't

When the world knows what beauty is, then there is ugliness; When the world knows what good is, then there is evil. Thus: Being and Non-being produce each other, Difficult and easy complement each other, Long and short calibrate each other, High and low contrast each other, Music and noise harmonize each other, and Fro

When all under heaven know beauty (mei) as beauty, There is then ugliness (o); When all know the good (shan) good, There is then the not good (pu shan). Therefore being and non-being give rise to each other, The difficult and easy complement each other, The long and short shape each other, The high and low lean on each other, Voices and instruments harmonize with one another, The front an

the sage is devoted to non action, Moves without teaching, Creates ten thousand things without instruction, Lives but does not own, Acts but does not presume, Accomplishes without taking credit. When no credit is taken, Accomplishment endures. up

ise Man's office Is to work by being still; He teaches not by speech But by accomplishment; He does for everything, Neglecting none; Their life he gives to all, Possessing none; And what he brings to pass Depends on no one else. As he succeeds, He takes no credit And just because he does not take it, Credit never leaves him.

't exist: except through the other. Profit doesn't exist; loss doesn't exist: except through the other. Therefore the master acts without setting a goal, and teaches that there is no teaching. Freedom from duality resides with him. Everything is his, but he has nothing. Every act is his, but he expects nothing. This is his accomplishment, which can never be destroyed. up

nt and back accompany each other. Therefore the sage chooses to: Manage affairs by taking no action; Teach without words; Allow all things to develop, but no to start; Produce, but not to possess; Care for, but not to master; Complete work, but not to claim credit, By not claiming credit, his credit will not be lost. up

d rear follow upon each other. Therefore the sage manages affairs without action, Carries out (hsing) teaching without speech (yen). Ten thousand things arise and he does not initiate them, They come to be and he claims no possession (yu) of them, He works (wei) without holding on, Accomplishes (ch'eng) without claiming merit. Because he does not claim merit, His merit does not go away. up

Chapter 3

Don't glorify
heroes, And
people will not
contend. Don't
treasure rare
objects, And no
one will steal.
Don't display
what people
desire, And their
hearts will not be
disturbed.
Therefore, the
Sage rules By
emptying hearts
an

If those who are
excellent find no
preferment, The
people will cease
to contend for
promotion. If
goods that are
hard to obtain are
not favored, The
people will cease
to turn robbers or
bandits. If things
much desired are
kept under cover,
Disturbance will
cease in the minds
of the people. The

A great man who
doesn't display
his talent has no
rivals. A wealthy
man who doesn't
flaunt his wealth
sees no thieves.
The master
teaches the
value of humility
and the futility of
amb

Do not ennoble
achievers, so the
people will not
become
contentious; Do
not value rare
commodities, so
the people will not
be tempted to
steal; Do not
display
temptations, so the
people's minds will
not be disturbed.
Therefore, a wise
ruler would:
Humble the peo

Do not honor
(shang) the worthy
(hsien), So that the
people will not
contend (cheng)
with one another.
Do not value (kuei)
hard-to-get goods,
So that the people
will not turn
robbers. Do not
show objects of
desire (k'o yü), So
that the people's
minds (hsin) are
not disturbed.
Therefore, when
the sage

d filling bellies,
By weakening
ambitions and
strengthening
bones; Leads
people Away
from knowing
and wanting;
Deters those
who know too
much From
going too far:
Practices
non-action And
the natural order
is not disrupted.
up

Wise Man's policy,
accordingly, Will
be to empty
people's hearts
and minds, To fill
their bellies,
weaken their
ambition, Give
them sturdy
frames and always
so, To keep them
uninformed,
without desire,
And knowing ones
not venturing to
act. Be still while
you work And
keep full control
Over all.

ition. He empties
their minds of all
they know and
helps them
extinguish
desires. Those
who think they
know cannot
understand him.
Don't work at
anything, and
everything will
work. up

ple's minds; Fill
their stomachs;
Weaken their
ambitions, and
Strengthen their
bodies. Always
keep the people
ignorant and
devoid of desire,
Even the cunning
ones dare not
agitate. Achieve
the ideal of taking
no action, Then
there will be no
misgoverned state.
up

rules: He empties
the minds (hsin) of
his people, Fills
their bellies,
Weakens their
wills (chih), And
strengthens their
bones. Always he
keeps his people
in no-knowledge
(wu-chih) and
no-desire (wu-yü),
Such that he who
knows dares not
act. Act by
no-action (wu-wei),
Then, nothing is
not in order. up

Chapter 4

Tao is empty- its
use never
exhausted.
Bottomless - the
origin of all
things. It blunts
sharp edges,
Unties knots,
Softens g

The Way is a
void, Used but
never filled: An
abyss it is, Like
an ancestor
From which all
things come. It
blunts
sharpness,
Resolves
tangles;

The Tao is
always used, but
never empties. It
is eternal and
infinite but is
nothing. You
can't fi

Tao is empty, yet
forever
inexhaustible. It
is so
far-reaching, the
source for
everything.
Blunting
sharpnesses,
resolving
conflicts,
softening lights.
It

Tao is a whirling
emptiness
(ch'ung), Yet
(erh) in use
(yung) is
inexhaustible
(ying).
Fathomless
(yuan), It seems
to be the
ancestor (tsung)
of ten thousand
beings. It blunts
the sharp, Unti

lare, Becomes
one with the
dusty world.
Deeply
subsistent - I
don't know
whose child it is.
It is older than
the Ancestor. up

It tempers light,
Subdues turmoil.
A deep pool it is,
Never to run dry!
Whose offspring
it may be I do not
know: It is like a
preface to God.

nd it even though
it is always here.
Since it creates
everything how
can we know
who created it.
up

thus harmonizes
the dusty world.
So deep and
profound, It has
forever existed. I
do not now
whose child it is,
It has existed
before the notion
of god. up

es the entangled,
Harmonizes the
bright, Mixes the
dust. Dark
(chan), It seems
perhaps to exist
(ts'un). I do not
know whose
child it is, It is an
image (hsiang) of
what precedes
God (Ti). up

Chapter 5

Heaven and Earth are not kind: The ten thousand things are straw dogs to them. The Sage is not kind: People are straw dogs to him. Yet Heaven and Earth A

Is then the world unkind? And does it treat all things Like straw dogs used in magic rites? The Wise Man too, is he unkind? And does he treat the folk Like straw dogs made to throw a

The Tao is impartial; good and evil both reside herein. The master is impartial, and regards all as equal. The Tao contains nothing

Heaven and earth are inhumane, They treat all things like straw dogs; The rule is inhumane, He treats his people like straw dogs. Between the heaven and earth, is it like a b

Heaven and earth are not humane (jen), They treat the ten thousand beings as straw dogs (ch'u kou). The sage is not humane (jen), He treats the hundred families as straw dogs (ch'u kou). Between heaven and ear

nd all the space between Are like a bellows: Empty but inexhaustible, Always producing more. Longwinded speech is exhausting. Better to stay centered. up

way? Between the earth and sky The space is like a bellows, Empty but unspent. When moved its gift is copious. Much talk means much exhaustion; Better far it is to keep your thoughts!

but is able to create anything. As it is used, it produces. If you talk of it your understanding will grow dim. Remain impartial. up

ellows? It is empty yet inexhaustible; and More agitations produce even more disturbances. Much arguments are destined to end, It is better to remain with the central core. up

th, How like a bellows (t'o yo) it is! Empty and yet inexhaustible, Moving and yet it pours out ever more. By many words one's reckoning (shu) is exhausted. It is better to abide by the center (shou chung). up

Chapter 6

The Valley Spirit never dies. It is called the Mysterious Female. The entrance top the Myste

The valley spirit is not dead: They say it is the mystic female. Her gateway is, they fur

The Tao is like a valley, receptive. Your true essence is the Tao, mysterious. Because it never dies it is mysterious. A

The valley spirit never dies, It is the mysterious female. The gate of the mysterious female, Is t

The Valley Spirit (ku shen) is deathless, It is called the Dark Mare (hsüan p'in). The door of the Dark Mare, Is called t

rious Female Is called the root of Heaven and Earth. Endless flow of inexhaustible energy. up

ther say, The base of heaven and earth. Constantly, and so forever, Use her without labor.

s it receives all we say it is feminine. From it arise all dreams. It continues without end and death cannot stop it. up

he root of Heaven and Earth. It exists forever in continuum, And using it, it is inexhaustible. up

he root of heaven and earth. Continuous (mien mien), it seems to exist (ts'un), Yet in use (yung) it is inexhaustible. up

Chapter 7

Heaven is long,
Earth enduring.
Long and
enduring
Because they do
not exist for
themselves.
Therefore the
Sage

The sky is
everlasting And
the earth is very
old. Why so?
Because the
world Exists not
for itself; It can
and will live on.
The Wise Man
ch

As the Tao can
never die, we call
it eternal.
Receiving all, we
call it infinite. The
birthless is
eternal. The
desireless is

Heaven is
permanent and
Earth
everlasting. The
reason Heaven
and Earth are
permanent and
everlasting is
that They do not
exist for
themselves.
Therefore they

Heaven and
earth are long
lasting (chiu).
The reason why
heaven and
earth are long
lasting: Because
they do not live
for self (pu tzu
sheng).
Therefore they
last long. Thus
the sage puts his
body (shen)

Steps back, but
is always in front,
Stays outside,
but is always
within. No
self-interest? Self
is fulfilled? up

oozes to be last
And so becomes
the first of all;
Denying self, he
too is saved. For
does he not
fulfillment find In
being an
unselfish man?

infinite. Seeing
this, a master
seeks nothing so
he has
everything. He
doesn't nourish
the ego, so his
nourishment it
total. up

last forever. Thus
the sage: Gets
ahead by staying
behind; Survives
by being selfless.
Is it no his being
selfless that
enables him to
fulfill his wishes?
up

behind, Yet his
body is in front.
He regards his
body as external,
Yet his body
remains in
existence (ts'un).
Is it not because
he is selfless (wu
szu), That he can
fulfill himself
(ch'eng ch'i szu).
up

Chapter 8

Best to be like water, Which benefits the ten thousand things And does not contend. It pools where humans disdain to dwell, Close to the Tao. Live in a good place. Ke

The highest goodness, water-like, Does good to everything and goes Unmurmuring to places men despise; But so, is close in nature to the Way. If the good of the house is from land, Or the good of the mind is depth, Or love is the

To be truly good, be like water which benefits all without knowing. Men who aspire to ascend benefit no being. But all are benefited by the natural descent of water. This is like the Tao. So seek a dwelling for shelter. Think when the need arises. Wh

The ultimate good is like water. Water benefits all things without competing with them. It stays at places where all people disdain, Therefore it is close to Tao. A habitat is good because of its location; A mind is good because of its profundity; A friend is good because o

A person with superior goodness (shan) is like water, Water is good in benefiting (li) all beings, Without contending (cheng) with any. Situated in places shunned (o) by many others, Thereby it is near (chi) Tao. (Such a person's) dwelling is the good earth, (His/her) mind (hsin) is the good deep water (yuan), (H

ep your mind deep. Treat others well. Stand by your word. Make fair rules. Do the right thing. Work when it's time. Only do not contend, And you will not go wrong. up

virtue of friendship, Or honesty blesses one's talk, Or in government, goodness is order, Or in business, skill is admired, Or the worth of an act lies in timing, Then peace is the goal of the Way By which no one ever goes astray.

en you deal with others, do so with compassion. When you speak to others, don't lie. Work at a profession for self-refinement as well as livelihood. Lead your family by simply following them. When you follow the natural path no mistake can be made. up

f his kindness; A statement is good because of its credibility; A government is good because of its excellent management; A worker is good because of his productivity; and A move is good because of its timeliness. Only by being not contentious, Will there be no ill will. up

is/her) associates are good kind people (jen), (His/her) speech shows good trust (hsin), (His/her) governing is the good order, (His/her) projects (shih) are carried out by good talents (neng), (His/her) activities (tung) are good in timing. Because he does not contend (pu cheng) with any, He commits no wrong. up

Chapter 9

Hold and fill it -
No as good as
stopping in time.
Measure and
pound it - It will
not long survive.
When gold and
jade

To take all you
want Is never as
good As to stop
when you
should. Scheme
and be sharp
And you'll not
keep it long. One
can never guard
His home when
it'

Acting naturally,
also know when
to stop naturally.
Balance is lost if
you would
continue. Base
your achievemen

Holding a cup to
fill it to brim, It is
better to stop in
time. Making a
sword extremely
sharp, It is hard
to keep its
sharpness for
long. Filling up a
hall with gold and
jade; It canno

To hold and fill (a
vessel) to the full
(ying), It had
better not be
done. To temper
and sharpen a
sword, Its edge
could not be kept
(pao) long. To fill
the hall with gold
and jade, There i

fill the hall, They
cannot be
guarded. Riches
and pride
Bequeath error.
Withdrawing
when work is
done: Heaven's
Tao. up

s full Of jade and
fine gold: Wealth,
power and pride
Bequeath their
own doom.
When fame and
success Come to
you, then retire.
This is the
ordained Way.

t not on results,
but on whether
you followed the
act. When the
act is complete, it
is gone. This is
serene. up

t be securely
guarded. He who
becomes
arrogant with
wealth and
power, Sows the
seeds of his own
misfortune.
Retire once the
work is
successfully
completed. This
is the way of
heaven. up

s no way to
guard (shou)
them. To be rich,
exalted, and
proud, This is to
invite blame
(chiu) upon
oneself. When
work is done
(sui), the person
(sheng) retires,
Such is the Tao
of heaven. up

Chapter 10

Can you balance
your life force
And embrace the
One Without
separation? Can
you control your
breath Gently
Like a baby?
Can you clarify
Your dark vision
Without blemish?
Can you love
people And
govern the
country Without
knowledge? Can
you open

Can you govern
your animal soul,
hold to the One
and never depart
from it? Can you
throttle your
breath, down to
the softness of
breath in a child?
Can you purify
your mystic vision
and wash it until it
is spotless? Can
you love all your
people, rule over
the land without
being known? Can
y

To keep the mind
balanced use the
body. Breathe
like an infant.
Then cleanse the
mind by letting
go of ideas. Love
people without
interfering. Allow
events to take
their natural
course.
Detached from

Command your
body and soul to
embrace the One,
Can there be no
separation?
Concentrate your
vital energy to
achieve complete
softness, Can you
be like an infant?
Cleansing your
thoughts and
purify your insight,
Can you be
flawless? In loving
your people and
governing your
state, Can you be
without
preconception? In
opening and clos

In bringing your
spiritual (ying) and
bodily (p'o) souls
to embrace the
One, Can (neng)
you never depart
(li) from it? In
concentrating your
breath to attain
softness, Can you
be like an infant
(ying erh)? In
cleansing your
mirror (lan) of the
dark (hsüan), Can
you make it
spotless? In
opening and
closing heaven's
gate (t'ien men),
Can you be the
female (tz'u

and close The
gate of heaven
Without clinging
to earth? Can
you brighten The
four directions
Without action?
Give birth and
cultivate. Give
birth and do not
possess. Act
without
dependence.
Excel but do not
rule. This is
called the dark
Te. up

ou be like a
female, and
passively open
and shut heaven's
gates? Can you
keep clear in your
mind the four
quarters of earth
and not interfere?
Quicken them,
feed them;
Quicken but do not
possess them. Act
and be
independent; Be
the chief but never
the lord: This
describes the
mystic virtue.

comings and
goings the mind
is clear. Don't
bullshit yourself!
By balancing it
you nurture it,
but it is not
yours. Acting
through it, but
expecting no
results.
Perfection comes
of its own
accord. up

ing the gate of
Heaven, Can you
behave like a
female? In
comprehending
and penetrating
the truth, Can you
be mindful of
taking no action
against Tao? In
producing and in
nurturing lives, you
are: To produce,
but not to possess;
To care for, but not
to control; To lead,
but not to
subjugate. This is
known as the
profound virtue. up

)? In being
enlightened (ming)
and
comprehending all,
Can you do it
without
knowledge? In
loving the people
and governing the
state, Can you
practice
non-action? To
give birth, to
nurture, To give
birth yet not to
claim possession
(yu), To act (wei)
yet not to hold on
to, To grow
(chang) yet not to
lord over (tsai),
This is called the
dark virtue (yüan
te). up

Chapter 11

Thirty spokes
join one hub. The
wheel's use
comes from
emptiness. Clay
is fired to make a
pot. The pot's
use comes from
emptiness.
Windo

Thirty spokes will
converge In the
hub of a wheel;
But the use of
the cart Will
depend on the
part Of the hub
that is void. With
a wall all around
A clay bowl is
molded; But the
use of the bowl
Will depend on
the part Of the
bowl

Without the hole
in the tap, the
water cannot
flow. A cup has
form for the
emptiness inside.
Houses have
four

Thirty spokes are
joined around the
wheel's hub, Its
non-being makes
the carriage
useful. Clay is
molded to make
a pot, Its
non-being
provides the utili

Thirty spokes
share one hub to
make a wheel.
Through its
non-being (wu),
There is (yu) the
use (yung) of the
carriage. Mold
clay into a vessel
(ch'i). Through its
non-being (wu),
There is (yu) the
use (yung) of the
vessel. Cut out
doors an

ws and doors are
cut to make a
room. The
room's use
comes from
emptiness.
Therefore,
Having leads to
profit, Not having
leads to use. up

that is void. Cut
out windows and
doors In the
house as you
build; But the use
of the house Will
depend on the
space In the
walls that is void.
So advantage is
had From
whatever is
there; But
usefulness rises
From whatever is
not.

walls and a roof,
but the space
inside is where
we live. Things
seem to exist,
but arise from
non-existence.
up

ty. Doors and
windows are cut
to make a room,
Their utility is
furnished by
non-being.
Therefore, Being
only facilitates,
non-being
provides utility.
up

d windows to
make a house.
Through its
non-being (wu),
There is (yu) the
use (yung) of the
house. Therefore
in the being
(yu-chih) of a
thing, There lies
the benefit (li). In
the non-being
(wu-chih) of a
thing, There lies
its use (yun). up

Chapter 12

Five colors
darken the eyes.
Five tones
darken the ears.
Five tastes jade
the palate.
Hunting and
racing madden
the heart. E

The five colors
darken the eye;
The five sounds
will deaden the
ear; The five
flavors weary the
taste; Chasing
the beasts of the
field Will drive a
man mad. The
goods that a

If you look at
bright light, you
go blind. If you
listen to loud
noise, you go
deaf. Tasting
many flavours
reduces the
tongue's

The five colours
may blind one's
eyes; The five
tones may
deafen one's
ears; The five
flavours may dull
one's taste;
Racing and
hunting may
madden one's
mind; Rare
commoditie

The five colors
blind a person's
eyes; The five
musical notes
deafen a
person's ears;
The five flavors
ruin a person's
taste buds.
Horse-racing,
hunting and
chasing, Drive a
pe

xotic goods
ensnarl human
lives. Therefore
the Sage Takes
care of the belly,
not the eye,
Chooses one,
rejects the other.
up

re hard to
procure Are
hobbles that slow
walking feet. So
the Wise Man
will do What his
belly dictates
And never the
sight of his eyes.
Thus he will
choose this but
not that.

sensitivity. Many
thoughts confuse
the mind. Many
desires break
your heart. Don't
crave anything.
Simply fulfil your
needs. up

s may prompt
people's illicit
activities.
Therefore, The
sage
emphasizes the
essentials of life,
not the
superficial
temptations.\So
he accepts this
and rejects the
other. up

rson's mind
(hsin) to
madness.
Hard-to-get
goods, Hinder a
person's actions.
Therefore the
sage is for the
belly, not for the
eyes. Therefore
he leaves this
and chooses
that. up

Chapter 13

Favour and disgrace are like fear. Honour and distress are like the self. What does this mean? Favour debases us. Afraid when we get it, Afraid when we lose it. The se

"Favor, like disgrace Brings trouble with it; High rank, like self, Involves acute distress." What does that mean, to say That "favor, like disgrace Brings trouble with it"? When favor is bestowed On one of low degree, Trouble will come with it. The loss of favor too Means trouble for that man. This, then, is what is meant By "favor, like disgrace Brings trouble wi

A man hopes to be successful and fears failure. Why? Because he is someone important. Neither hope nor fear can sway a master though. Why? Because a master knows he is no one important. Free from

Exceptional favour or disgrace causes anxieties. Treat calamities as treats to your body. What is meant by "exceptional favour or disgrace causes anxieties"? Exceptional favour is granted to someone of low status: Whoever receives it is anxious about what is expected of him; Whoever loses it is anxious about the accompanying disgrace. This explains "exceptional

Accept honors and disgraces as surprises, Treasure great misfortunes as the body. Why say: "Accept honors and disgraces as surprises"? Honors elevate (shang), Disgraces depress (hsia). One receives them surprised, Loses them surprised. Thus: "Accept honors and disgraces as surprises." Why say: "Treas

If embodies distress. No self, No distress. Respect the world as your self: The world can be your lodging. Love the world as your self: The world can be your trust. up

th it." What does it mean, to say That "rank, like self, Involves acute distress"? I suffer most because Of me and selfishness. If I were selfless, then What suffering would I bear? In governing the world, Let rule entrusted be To him who treats his rank As if it were his soul; World sovereignty can be Committed to that man Who loves all people As he loves himself.

ideas of self-importance even life and death matter not. Success and failure lose all meaning. Here, how can hope and fear touch you? Seeing all things as equal you love all things as yourself. up

favour or disgrace cause anxieties". What is meant by "treat calamities as threats to your body"? The reason I encounter calamities is that I have e a body. If I no longer have a body, what calamity do I have? Therefore, He who values the world as his self merits the confidence of the world; He who loves the world as his self deserves the trust of the world. up

ure great misfortunes as the body"? I have great misfortunes, Because I have a body. If I don't have a body, What misfortunes do I have? Therefore treasure the body as the world, As if the body can be entrusted to the world. Love the body as the world, As if the body can be entrusted to the world. up

Chapter 14

Seeing but not seeing, we call it dim. Listening but not hearing, we call it faint. Groping but not touching, we call it subtle. These three cannot be fully grasped. Therefore they become one. Rising, it is not bright; setting it is not dark

They call it elusive, and say That one looks But it never appears. They say that indeed it is rare, Since one listens, But never a sound. Subtle, they call it, and say That one grasps it But never gets hold. These three complaints amount To only one, which is Beyond all resolution. At rising, it does not illumine; At setting, no darkness ensues; It stretches far back

The Tao cannot be seen, so don't look for it. You can't hear it, so don't listen for it. It is no-thing, so don't try to touch it. Timeless and dimensionless, it cannot be n

Looking at without seeing it, it is invisible; Listening to without hearing it, it is inaudible; Holding onto without finding it, it is intangible; These three need no further inquiry, they are thus merged into the One: It is not bright above, nor dark below, Boundless beyond description, and reverting back to n

What is looked at but not (pu) seen, Is named the extremely dim (yi). What is listened to but not heard, Is named the extremely faint (hsi). What is grabbed but not caught, Is named the extremely small (wei). These three cannot be comprehended, Thus they blend into one. As to the one, its coming up is not light, Its going down is not darkness. Unceasing, unnameable, Again it reverts to nothi

. It moves all things back to where there is nothing Meeting it there is no front, following it there is no back. Live in the ancient Tao, Master the existing present, Understand the source of all things. This is called the record of Tao. up

To that nameless estate Which existed before the creation. Describe it as form yet unformed; As shape that is still without shape; Or say it is vagueness confused: One meets it and it has no front; One follows and there is no rear. If you hold ever fast To that most ancient Way, You may govern today. Call truly that knowledge Of primal beginnings The clue to the Way.

amed. But all things are contained in it. Subtle beyond understanding. It is a beginningless and endless present. Not trying to find it, you can be it. Look, here you are! up

othingness. It is a shape without form, an image without substance, and A blurred ambiguity. Facing it, one sees no head, and following it, one sees no back. Holding fast the Tao of old, For the understanding of current discoveries, One may learn the beginning of Creation. This is called the principle of Tao. up

ng. Therefore it is called the formless form, The image (hsiang) of nothing. Therefore it is said to be illusive and evasive (hu-huang). Come toward it one does not see its head, Follow behind it one does not see its rear. Holding on to the Tao of old (ku chih tao), So as to steer in the world of now (chin chih yu). To be able to know the beginning of old, It is to know the thread of Tao. up

Chapter 15

The ancients who followed Tao:
Dark, wondrous, profound,
penetrating. Deep beyond knowing.
Because they cannot be known,
They can only be described.
Cautious, like crossing a winter stream. Hesitant, like respecting one's neighbours.
Polite, like a guest. Yielding, Like ice about to melt

The excellent masters of old,
Subtle, mysterious, mystic, acute,
Were much too profound for their times. Since they were not then understood, It is better to tell how they looked. Like men crossing streams in the winter, How cautious! As if all around there were danger, How watchful! As if they were guests on every occasion, How dignified! Like ice just beginning to

All past masters of the Tao had deep penetration of the subtle. This subtlety cannot be understood. Therefore the masters seem mysterious. All we can describe is their manner. They took care with every action, Watched like a hawk, Respected all, Adapted to every situation

A good practitioner of Tao of old is: A man of subtlety with deep insight, But it is too profound to understand Simply because he cannot be understood, one has to describe him as follow: Cautious, like one crossing a frozen stream in winter; Hesitant, like one fearing his surrounding neighbours; Reserved, like a polite guest; Supple, like ice about to melt; Honest, like a piece of

It; Blank, like uncarved wood. Open, like a valley. Mixing freely, like muddy water. Calm the muddy water, It becomes clear. Move the inert, It comes to life.? Those who sustain Tao Do not wish to be full. Because they do not wish to be full They can fade away Without further effort. up

melt, Self-effacing! Like a wood-block untouched by a tool, How sincere! Like a valley awaiting a guest, How receptive! Like a torrent that rushes along, And so turbid! Who, running dirty, comes clean like still waters? Who, being quiet, moves others to fullness of life? It is he who, embracing the Way, is not greedy; Who endures wear and tear without needing renewal.

; and were firm inside so their clarity was always evident. Practice stilling the mind amidst everyday life, till it clears. Remain unmoved till the movement comes of its own accord. Don't try to fulfill the Tao, but remain empty. Only by being empty can you be filled. up

f of virgin wood; Open-minded, like a valley; and Confused, like muddy water. Who can get rid of the muddiness? It gradually clears though stillness. Who can revitalize it after long stillness? It gradually returns to life through activities. A practitioner of Tao has no desire for filling to brim. Just because of no filling to the brim, He will not be worn out but be renewed. up

like uncarved wood, Open, like a valley, Chaotic (hun), like murky (cho) water. What can stop the murkiness? Quieting (ching) down, gradually it clarifies (ch'ing). What can keep still for long? Moving, gradually it stirs into life. Those who keep this Tao, Do not want to be filled to the full (ying). Because they are not full, They can renew (hsin) themselves before being worn out (pi). up

Chapter 16

Attain complete emptiness, Hold fast to stillness. The ten thousand things stir about; I only watch for their going back. Things grow and grow, But each goes back to its root. Going back to the root is stillness. This means returning to what is. Returning to what is Means going back to the ordinar

Touch ultimate emptiness, Hold steady and still. All things work together: I have watched them reverting, And have seen how they flourish And return again, each to his roots. This, I say, is the stillness: A retreat to one's roots; Or better yet, return To the will of God, Which is, I say, to constancy. The knowled

Empty the mind by not thinking of gain or loss. Follow your heart in all matters and the mind isn't stirred. Even though the misery of others is apparent, you contemplate their ultimate destiny. That destiny is enlightenment. Being one with the Tao is e

Attain the utmost emptiness of mind, Maintain the utmost stillness. While all things are simultaneously developing, I can observe their cycles. Though everything is flourishing, each will return to its root, Returning to the root means stillness, and Stillness marks the cycle of life. The cycle of life is an eternal truth, Knowing the tru

Reach the pole of emptiness (hsü-chi), Abide in genuine quietude (ching). Ten thousand beings flourish together, I am to contemplate (kuan) their return (fu). Now things grow profusely, Each again returns (kuei) to its root. To return to the root is to attain quietude (ching), It is called to recover life (ming). To recover life is to attain the Everlasting (ch'ang), To know the Everlasting (ch'ang) is

y. Understanding the ordinary: Enlightenment. Not understanding the ordinary: Blindness creates evil. Understanding the ordinary: Mind opens. Mind opening leads to compassion, Compassion to nobility, Nobility to heavenliness, Heavenliness to Tao. Tao endures. Your body dies. There is no danger. up

ge of constancy I call enlightenment and say That not to know it Is blindness that works evil. But when you know What eternally is so, You have stature And stature means righteousness And righteousness is kingly And kingliness divine And divinity is the Way Which is final. Then, though you die, You shall not perish.

nlightenment. Here you are serenely impartial. Being someone is a delusion. Here you are separate and confused. Impartial, you shine on existence like the sun, caring not what or who you shine on. At one with the Tao, birth and death cannot touch you. up

th is called enlightenment, Not knowing the truth and acting blindly results in disaster. Knowing the truth enhances forbearance, Forbearance leads to objectivity, Objectivity becomes the universal rule, The universal rule is in accord with Nature, and Nature is in harmony with Tao. Tao is everlasting, and Prevails over one's lifetime. up

to be illumined (ming). Not knowing (chih) the Everlasting (ch'ang), One commits evils wantonly. Knowing the Everlasting one becomes all containing (yung). To be all containing is to be public (kung). To be public is to be kingly (wang). To be kingly is to be like heaven. To be like heaven is to be like Tao. To be like Tao is to last long. This is to lose the body without becoming exhausted (pu tai). up

Chapter 17

Great rising and falling - People only know it exists. Next they see and praise. Soon they fear. Finally they despise. Without funda

As for him who is highest, The people just know he is there. His deputy's cherished and praised; Of the third, they are frightened; The fourth, they despise and revile. If you trust people less than eno

The master of the Tao is the highest. The next is the person who causes others to love him. The next is the person who causes others to fear him. The lowest is the person who causes others to despise

The best ruler, the people only know of his existence; The next best, the people praise and want to be near him; The next, the people fear him; The last, the people despise him. If ther

The best government, the people know it is just there. The next best, they love and praise it. The next, they fear it. The next, they revile against it. When you don't trust (hsi

mental trust
There is no trust at all. Be careful in valuing words. When the work is done, Everyone says We just acted naturally. up

ugh, Some of them never trust you. He is aloof, as if his talk Were priced beyond the purchasing; But once his project is contrived, The folk will want to say of it: "Of course! We did it by ourselves!"

him. The master trusts in the Tao, therefore doesn't try to improve others. Limited in his words, he lets his actions speak loudly. Others begin following his actions and success comes naturally. up

e is not enough faith, There will be no faith. The best ruler is so relaxed, he hardly talks. When he successfully completes his work, People all say that for us, it is only natural. up

n) [the people] enough, Then they are untrustworthy (pu hsin). Quiet, why value words (yen)? Work is accomplished, things are done. People all say that I am natural (tzu-jan). up

Chapter 18

Great Tao
rejected:
Benevolence and
righteousness
appear. Learning
and knowledge
professed: Great
Hypocrites sprin

The mighty Way
declined among
the folk And then
came kindness
and morality.
When wisdom
and intelligence
appeared, They
brought with
them a great
hypocrisy. The

When people are
separated from
the Tao, they are
taught to be kind
and ethical.
Given intellectual
knowledge they
lose their
intelligence.
They are tra

When the great
Tao declines,
Then humanity
and justice arise.
When knowledge
and cleverness
appear, The
great hypocrisy
follows. When
the six family r

On the decline of
the great Tao,
There are
humanity (jen)
and
righteousness (i).
When
intelligence (hui)
and knowledge
(chih) appear,
There is great
artificiality (wei).
When th

g up. Family
relations
forgotten: Filial
piety and
affection arise.
The nation
disordered:
Patriots come
forth. up

six relations were
no more at
peace, So codes
were made to
regulate our
homes. The
fatherland grew
dark, confused
by strife: Official
loyalty became
the style.

ined to be
obedient and
polite to make
them consistent.
Only by
suppressing their
individuality will
they serve
abstract
concepts, such
as a country. up

elationships are
in disharmony,
Then filial piety
and parental love
strengthen.
When a state is
in disorderly
crisis, The loyal
ministers stand
out. up

e six relations
are not in
harmony, There
are filial piety
(hsiao) and
parental love
(tz'u). When a
nation is in
darkness (hun)
and disorder
(lüan), There are
loyal ministers.
up

Chapter 19

Banish learning,
discard
knowledge:
People will gain
a hundredfold.
Banish
benevolence,
discard
righteousness:
People will return
to duty and
compassion.
Banish skill,
discard pr

Get rid of the
wise men! Put
out the
professors! Then
people will profit
A hundredfold
over. Away with
the kind ones;
Those righteous
men too! And let
people return To
the graces of
home. Root out
the artisans;
Banish the
profiteers! And
bandits

Ideas of holiness
and wisdom will
hamper your
progress. Ideas
of morality and
justice cannot
replace what is
written on
people's hearts.
The idea of
profiting off
others causes
thie

Reject sageness
and abandon
knowledge, The
people will
benefit a
hundredfold.
Reject humanity
and abandon
justice, The
people will return
to filial piety and
parental love.
Reject
cleverness and
abandon p

Eliminate sagacity
(sheng), discard
knowledge (chih),
People will be
profited (li) a
hundredfold.
Eliminate humanity
(jen), discard
righteousness (i),
People will again
practice filial piety
and parental love.
Abolish artistry
(ch'iao), discard
profit-seeking (

ofit: There will be
no more thieves.
These three
statements are
not enough. One
more step is
necessary. Look
at plain silk; hold
uncarved wood.
The self
dwindles; desires
fade. up

and robbers Will
not come to
plunder. But if
these three
prove not
enough To
satisfy the mind
and heart, More
relevant, then, let
there be A visible
simplicity of life,
Embracing
unpretentious
ways, And small
self-interest And
poverty of
coveting.

ves to appear.
Since these
three ideas are
man made, they
are not eternal.
Therefore they
should be
avoided. Patient,
compassionate,
and desireless,
you are in step
with the Tao. up

rofit, Robbers
and thieves will
disappear. These
three are
insufficient to
form a doctrine.
Let there be
something for the
people to commit
to: Be plain and
simple, and
Curtail
selfishness and
desires. up

li), Robbers and
thieves shall
disappear. These
three pairs adorn
(wen) what is
deficient (pu tsu).
Therefore, let
there be the
advice: Look to the
undyed silk, hold
on to the uncarved
wood (p'u),
Reduce your
sense of self (szu)
and lessen your
desires (yü). up

Chapter 20

Banish learning,
no more grief.
Between Yes and
No How much
difference?
Between good and
evil How much
difference?? What
others fear I must
fear - How
pointless! People
are wreathed in
smiles As if at a
carnival banquet. I
alone am passive,
giving no sign,
Like an infant who
has not yet smiles.
Forlorn as if I had
no h

ome. Others have
enough and more,
I alone am left out.
I have the mind of
a fool, Confused,
confused. Others
are bright and
intelligent, I alone
and dull, dull,
Drifting on the
ocean, Blown
about endlessly.
Others have plans,
I alone am
wayward and
stubborn, I alone
am different from
others, Like a baby
in the womb. up

, I alone seem to
be left out; So
unconcerned, as if
I have a mind of an
ignorant man.
Common folks are
clear-minded, I
alone seem to be
mindless!
Common folks are
seriously engaged,
I alone seem to be
wandering: Drifting
like the vast sea;
and Aimless, like
the long wind. All
the people are
purposeful, I alone
and stubborn and
out of step. I alone
differ from others,
but do value being
sustained by the
Mother. up

Chapter 21

Great Te appears Flowing from Tao. Tao in action - Only vague and intangible. Intangible and vague, But within it are images. Vague and intangible; Within are entities. Shadowy and obscure;

The omnipresent Virtue will take shape According only to the Way. The Way itself is like some thing Seen in a dream, elusive, evading one. In it are images, elusive, evading one. In it are things like shadows in tw

The master has separated from mind, and the great virtuous Tao is. The mind is like a foot. If it follows that which is greater it is useful. If it tries to lead of its own volition it will lead to di

Creation of everything in the universe follows only Tao. The material universe created by Tao seems unclear and blurred: So blurred and so unclear, yet in it there are images; So unclear and so blurred, yet in it there are things; So dim and so invisible, yet

The features (yung) of the vast (k'ung) Te, Follows entirely (wei) from Tao. Tao as a thing, Is entirely illusive (huang) and evasive (hu). Evasive and illusive, In it there is image (hsiang). Illusive and evasive, In it there is thinghood (wu). Dark and dim, In it there is life seed (ching). I

Within there is life, Life so real, That within it there is trust. From the beginning its name is not lost But reappears through multiple origins. How do I know these origins? Like this. up

ilight. In it are essences, subtle but real, Embedded in truth. From of old until now, Under names without end, The First, the Beginning is seen. How do I know the beginning of all, What its nature may be? By these!

saster. The Tao is beyond conception, so drop all ideas. If you cling to anything it cannot provide nourishment. Neither inside nor outside, the Tao is non-dual. It can only be known by not knowing. up

in it there is essence. The essence is very real, and in it there is evidence. From the beginning until now, the naming has never stopped. So the beginning of many things may be understood. How do I know the many situations at the beginning? Through this. up

ts life seed being very genuine (chen), In it there is growth power (hsin). As it is today, so it was in the days of old (ku), Its name goes not away (ch'ü), So that we may survey (yüeh) the origins of the many (chung fu). How do I know that the origins of the many are such? Because of this. up

Chapter 22

Crippled become whole, Crooked becomes straight, Hollow becomes full, Worn becomes new, Little becomes more, Much becomes delusion. Therefore the Sages cling to the One And take care of this world; Do not display themselves And therefore shine. Do not

The crooked shall be made straight And the rough places plain; The pools shall be filled And the worn renewed; The needy shall receive And the rich shall be perplexed. So the Wise Man cherishes the One, As a standard to the world: Not displaying himself, He is famous; Not asserting himself,

Separate yourself and become whole. Yield and become firm. Be empty so you can be filled. Die so you can be reborn. Lose everything you have, and have it all. The master through the Tao sets and example for all. He doesn't show off so his depth is evident. Free from am

To yield is to be preserved whole, To be bent is to become straight, To be low is to be filled, To be worn is to be renewed, To have little is to gain, To have too much is to be confused. Thus the sage embraces the One, And becomes a model for the world. He does not: Insist on his own views, thus he has a clear view; Justify

Bent, thus (tse) preserved whole, Unjustly accused, thus exonerated (chih), Hollow, thus filled (ying), Battered (pi), thus renewed, Scanty, thus receiving (te), Much, thus perplexed. Therefore the sage embraces the One (pao i). He becomes the model (shih) of the world. Not self-seeing, hence he is enlightened (ming). Not self-justifying, he

assert themselves and therefore stand out. Do not praise themselves And therefore succeed. Do not contend And therefore no one under heaven Can contend with them. The old saying Crippled becomes whole Is not empty words. It becomes whole and returns. up

He is distinguished; Not boasting his powers, He is effective; Taking no pride in himself, He is chief. Because he is no competitor, No one in all the world can compete with him. The saying of the men of old Is not in vain: "The crooked shall be made straight-" To be perfect, return to it.

bition, he can be trusted. Having lost his identity, people can identify with him. Never disagreeing, no one can disagree with him. When the ancient masters said: "Separate yourself and become whole", they weren't doing so lightly. Trust the masters and become whole. up

himself, thus he sees the truth; Boast of his achievements, thus he is given credit; Become arrogant, thus grows in stature. Simply because he is not contentious, No one in the world can contend against him. Is the ancient saying to yield is to be preserved whole, empty words? It is truly perfect and should be preserved. up

nce he is outstanding. Not showing off (fa) his deeds, hence he is meritorious. Not boasting (ching) of himself, hence he leads (chang). Because he is not contentious (pu cheng), Hence no one under heaven can contend with him. What the ancients say: "Bent, thus preserved whole," Are these empty words? Be preserved whole and return (kuei). up

Chapter 23

Spare words;
nature's way.
Violent winds do
not blow all
morning. Sudden
rain cannot pour
all day. What
causes these
things? Heaven
and Earth. If
Heaven and Earth
do not blow and
pour for long, How
much less should
humans?
Therefore in
following Tao:
Those on the

Sparing indeed is
nature of its talk:
The whirlwind will
not last the
morning out; The
cloudburst ends
before the day is
done. What is it
that behaves itself
like this? The earth
and sky! And if it
be that these Cut
short their speech,
how much more
yet should man! If
you work by the
Way, You will be
of the Way; If you

To be limited in
speech is
natural. Clouds
may come, but
when they pass
the sun shines
through. Your
words may
come, but when
they pass there
is silence. This is
the natural way
of the Tao. When
things come, let
them. When
things pas

Nature utters few
words. Thus:
Violent winds
seldom last for a
whole morning,
Pouring rains
rarely persist for a
full day. Who is
responsible?
Heaven and Earth.
Even Heaven and
Earth do not
persist for long,
how should human
beings? Therefore
the practitioner of
Tao knows that:
He who follows
Tao identifies with
the follower of
Tao; He who is
virtuous identifies
wit

Nature speaks
(yen) little. Hence
a squall lasts not a
whole morning, A
rainstorm
continues not a
whole day. What
causes (wei)
these? Heaven
and earth. Even
[the actions of]
heaven and earth
do not last long,
How much less
[the works] of
humans?
Therefore one who
follows Tao
identifies with Tao,
One who follows te
(nature)

way become the
way, Those who
gain become the
gain, Those who
lose become the
loss. All within the
Tao: The wayfarer,
welcome upon the
way, Those who
gain, welcome
within gain, Those
who lose, welcome
withon loss.
Without trust in
this, There is no
trust at all. up

work through its
virtue you will be
given the virtue;
Abandon either
one And both
abandon you.
Gladly then the
Way receives
Those who choose
to walk in it; Gladly
too its power
upholds Those
who choose to use
it well; Gladly will
abandon greet
Those who to
abandon drift.
Little faith is put in
them Whose faith
is small.

s, let them.
Following the
natural flow you
will embody the
Tao. Virtue can
be experienced
by the virtuous.
Those who lose
the natural way
become lost. If
you don't trust in
your natural
responses, you
make yourself
untrustworthy. up

h the person of
virtue; He who lost
faith identifies with
the faithless. He
who is identified
with Tao, the
follower of Tao is
also happy to be
with him; He who
is virtuous, the
person of virtue is
also happy to be
with him; He who
is faithless, the
faithless person is
also happy to be
with him. He who
has not enough
faith in others
commands no faith
from others. up

identifies with te
(nature). One who
follows shih (loss)
identifies with shih.
One who identifies
with Tao is glad to
be with Tao. One
who identifies with
te is glad to be
with te. One who
identifies with shih
is glad to be with
shih. When you
don't trust (hsin)
(the people)
enough, Then they
are untrustworthy
(pu hsin). up

Chapter 24

Upon tiptoe: no way to stand.
Clambering: no way to walk.
Self-display: no way to shine.
Self-assertion: no way to succeed.
Self-praise: no way to flourish.

On tiptoe your stance is unsteady; Long strides make your progress unsure; Show off and you get no attention; Your boasting will mean you have failed; Asserting yourself brings no credit; Be

Strive for more, and you lose what you have. Hurry ahead and you will miss something, and then have to go back. Boast of achievements, and they will be lost. Define who you are, and you

He who stands on tiptoe to be tall is unstable; He who straddles to be fast is slow. He who insists on his own views has no clear view; He who justifies his own errors sees no truth. He who boasts of his own achievements

One who tiptoes cannot stand. One who straddles cannot walk. One who sees himself is not enlightened (ming). One who justifies himself is not outstanding. One who shows off (fa) his deeds is not meritorious. One who boasts

urish.
Complacency: no way to endure. According to Tao, Excessive food, Extraneous activity Inspire disgust. Therefore the follower of Tao Moves on. up

proud and you will never lead. To persons of the Way, these traits Can only bring distrust; they seem Like extra food for parasites. So those who choose the Way, Will never give them place.

u will lose your true self. Try to control others, and you will be controlled by them. These traits represent wasted energy spent on the ego. The master has long done away with them. up

nts harms his credibility; He who is arrogant experiences no growth in wisdom. From the point of view of Tao, They are like spoiled food and acts of nuisance which all detest. Therefore followers of Tao avoid them. up

sts (ching) of himself does not lead (chang). These to a Taoist are called: Excess nature (yü te) and superfluous actions (shui hsing), Avoided (o) even by things. Therefore the Taoist does not indulge (ch'u) in them. up

Chapter 25

Something unformed and complete Before heaven and Earth were born, Solitary and silent, Stands alone and unchanging. Pervading all things without limit. It is like the mother of all things under heaven, But I don't know its name - Better call it Tao. Better call it great. Great m

Something there is, whose veiled creation was Before the earth or sky began to be; So silent, so aloof and so alone, It changes not, nor fails, but touches all: Conceive it as the mother of the world. I do not know its name: A name for it is "Way"; Pressed for designation, I call it Great. Great means outgoing, Outgo

Before the universe was manifest a perfect emptiness abided. It is eternally still and silent, but creates infinite things. Not having a name, I call it the Tao. Being indescribable, I call it great. Infinite things constantly flow through it, never ceasin

There was a chaotic formation of matter, Before the existence of Heaven and Earth. It was so noiseless, so shapeless, all alone and unchanging, It is moving around endlessly. It can be the mother of Heaven and Earth. I do not know its name, but call it Tao. If I must I name it Great Reality. Being great means receding, R

There was something nebulous existing (yu wu hun ch'eng), Born before heaven and earth. Silent, empty, Standing alone (tu), altering not (pu kai), Moving cyclically without becoming exhausted (pu tai), Which may be called the mother of all under heaven. I know not its name, I give its alias (tzu), Tao. If forced to picture it, I say it is "great" (ta). To say it is "great" is to say it is "m

eans passing on. Passing on means going far. Going far means returning. Therefore Tao is great, And heaven, And earth, And humans. Four great things in the world. Aren't humans one of them? Humans follow earth Earth follows heaven Heaven follows Tao. Tao follows its own nature. up

ing, far-reaching, Far-reaching, return. The Way is great, The sky is great, The earth is great, The king also is great. Within the realm These four are great; The king but stands For one of them. Man conforms to the earth; The earth conforms to the sky; The sky conforms to the Way; The Way conforms to its own nature.

g. The Tao is great, The universe is great, The earth is great, Man is great. Man must follow the natural laws of the earth, The earth must follow the natural laws of the universe, The universe must follow the natural laws of the Tao, The Tao simply is. up

eceding means going faraway and Being faraway is followed by returning to the origin. Therefore, Tao is great, Heaven is great, Earth is great and Humanity is also great. There are four great realities in the universe, and Humanity is one of them. Humanity follows the Earth; Earth, Heaven; Heaven, Tao and Tao, Nature. up

oving away" (shih), To say it is "moving away" is to say it is "far away" (yüan), To say it is "far away" is to say it is "returning" (fan). Therefore Tao is great, Heaven is great, Earth is great, The king is also great. In the realm there are four greats, And the king is one of them. Humans follow (fa) earth, Earth follows heaven, Heaven follows Tao, Tao follows self-becoming (tzu-jan). up

Chapter 26

Gravity is the
root of lightness,
Stillness the
master of
passion. The
Sage travels all
day But does not
leave the
baggage-cart;
When
surrounded by
magnifice

The heavy is
foundation for
the light; So
quietness is
master of the
deed. The Wise
Man, though he
travel all the day,
Will not be
separated from
his goods. So
even if the scene
is glorious to
view, He keeps
his p

Something can
only be heavy
relative to
something
lighter.
Movement can
only occur
relative to
something
unmoved. The
master may
travel all day, but
remains
motionless.
There may be
amazing sights,
but he never

Heavy objects
provide footing
for the lighter
ones, Calm
disposition exerts
control over
restlessness.
The wise ruler
travels all day
without leaving
his heavy
supplies. Even at
the magnificent
sights, he

The heavy
(chung) is root
(ken) to the light
(ch'ing); The
tranquil (ching) is
master (chün) to
the agitated
(tsao). Therefore
the sage travels
all day, Without
leaving (li) his
baggage wagon
(tzu chung).
Although he has
glorious palaces

nt scenery
Remains calm
and still. When a
lord of ten
thousand
chariots Behaves
lightly in this
world, Lightness
loses its root,
Passion loses its
master. up

lace, at peace,
above it all. For
how can one
who rules Ten
thousand
chariots Give up
to lighter moods
AS all the world
may do? If he is
trivial, His
ministers are
lost; If he is
strenuous, There
is no master
then.

looks. A father
shouldn't act the
fool, and ignore
the needs of his
family. If you
take your
responsibilities
lightly, you lose
the basis of your
being. If you fall
prey to
restlessness you
cannot be
relaxed. up

remain relaxed
and unperturbed.
Why than the
lord of ten
thousand
chariots appear
light-headed in
public? Being
light-headed
reflects the loss
of footing, Being
restless signifies
the loss of
control. up

(yung kuan), He
avoids its
sumptuous
apartments
(yen-ch'u). How
could the Lord of
ten thousand
chariots,
Conduct himself
lightly in the
world? One who
acts lightly loses
his foundation
(pen); One who
is agitated loses
his master
(chün). up

Chapter 27

Good travelers leave no tracks. Good words leave no trace. Good counting needs no markers. Good doors have no bolts Yet cannot be forced. Good knots have no rope But cannot be untied. In this way the Sage Always helps people And rejects none, Always helps all beings, And rejects non

A good runner leaves no tracks. A good speech has no flaws to censure. A good computer uses no tallies. A good door is well shut without bolts and cannot be opened. A good knot is tied without rope and cannot be loosed. The Wise Man is always good at helping people, so that none are cast out; he is always good at

The master travels the natural path, which has no destination, and on which no tracks can be left. A good trader follows the market wherever it goes. A good teacher lets the students guide him. A master is present for all, both saints and sinners. All situations are used and nothing is

An excellent walker leaves no track; An excellent speech contains no flaw; An excellent reckoner uses no counter; A well-shut door uses no mechanism, yet none can open it; A well-tied know uses no rope, yet none can untie it. Similarly, The sage always excels in saving people, thus there is no useless people. The sage always excels in saving things, thus the

Good (shan) running leaves no tracks, Good speech has no flaws, Good counting uses no counters, A good lock uses no bolts yet cannot be opened, A good knot uses no rope yet cannot be untied. Hence the sage is always good at saving people, Therefore no one is rejected. He is always good at saving things, Therefore nothing is rejected. Thi

e. This is called practicing brightness. Therefore the good person is the bad person's teachers, And the bad person Is the good person's resource. Not to value the teacher, Not to love the resource, Causes great confusion even for the intelligent. This is called the vital secret. up

saving things, so that none are thrown away. This is called applied intelligence. Surely the good man is the bad man's teacher; and the bad man is the good man's business. If the one does not respect his teacher, or the other doesn't love his business, his error is very great. This is indeed an important secret.

dismissed. This is called spreading the light. A man, who considers himself good, must be intimate with that which is bad. A man, who considers himself bad, must know the good. Therefore the master sees no distinction between the two. For this reason the master and disciple are equal. up

re is no abandoned thing. This is called the innate enlightenment. It follows that: A superior person if the teacher of the lesser person, and The lesser person provides lessons for the superior person. The person who does not value his teacher, nor care about the lessons, Is deeply confused despite the person's intelligence. This is an important subtlety. up

s is called following the light (ming). Therefore the good person, Is the not-good (pu-shan) person's teacher. The not-good (pu-shan) person, Is the good person's capital. One who does not honor (kuei) the teacher, Or love (ai) the capital, Is greatly confounded though knowledgeable (chih). This is called the important mystery (miao). up

Chapter 28

Know the male, maintain the female, Become the channel of the world, And Te will endure. Return to infancy. Know the white, sustain the black, Become the pattern of the world, And Te will not falter. Return to the uncarved block

Be aware of your masculine nature; But by keeping the feminine way, You shall be to the world like a canyon, Where the Virtue eternal abides, And go back to become as a child. Be aware of the white all around you; But remembering the black that is there, You shall be to the world like a tester, Whom the Virtue eternal, unerring, Redirects to the infinite past.

Know how to be assertive but remain passive. Be receptive towards all situations and you will be in accordance with them, like a little child. Understanding the conditionality of opposites, you can avoid all opposition. Never in error, you are virtuous. People are bound to follow

He who knows the male, yet keeps to the female, Is like the ravine of the world. Being the ravine of the world, He never departs from the eternal virtue, and Returns to the state of harmony with Nature as in infancy. He who knows the white, yet keeps to the black, Is the model for the world. Being the model for the world, He never deviates from the eternal virtue, and Returns to the state of self

. Know honour, sustain disgrace, Become the valley of the world, And Te will prevail. Return to simplicity. Simplicity divided becomes utensils That are used by the Sage as high official. But great governing does not carve up. up

Be aware of your glory and honor; But in never relinquishing shame, You shall be to the world like a valley, Where Virtue eternal, sufficient, Sends you back to the Virginal Block. When the Virginal Block is asunder, And is made into several tools, To the ends of the Wise Man directed, They become then his chief officers: For "The Master himself does not carve."

with such and example. Know the personal, but keep to the impersonal: Accept the world as it is. If you accept the world as it is you will naturally be humble. How can the impersonal be arrogant? In this way the master is like a block of wood, which can be carved into any shape. up

simplicity as in primordial times. He who knows glory, but keeps to humility, Is like the valley of the world. Being the valley of the world, he is sufficient in the eternal virtue, and Returns to the state of natural goodness like virgin blocks. When the blocks are dispersed and found useful as tools, The wise ruler employs them to govern and lead. Therefore the great leader does not destroy Nature. up

Chapter 29

Trying to control
the world? I see
you won't
succeed. The
world is a
spiritual vessel
And cannot be
controlled. Those
who control, fail.
Those who
grasp, lose.
Some go forth,
some are le

As for those who
would take the
whole world To
tinker as they see
fit, I observe that
they never
succeed: For the
world is a sacred
vessel Not to be
altered by man.
The tinker will spoil
it; Usurpers will
lose it. For indeed
there are things
That must move
ahea

You cannot
change the world,
only yourself. The
world is in
constant natural
change, how could
you add to it? If
you try to change it
you will ruin
yourself. If you
treat it like an
object, you
objectify yourself.
Simply follow the
natural flow of the
changes:
Sometimes lead,
Sometimes follow,
Sometimes move,
Somet

Whoever intends
to conquer the
empire through
willful actions, I
foresee that he
will not succeed.
The empire is a
complex
organism, no
willful action
should be taken.
He who so acts
fails. He who so
exerts control
loses

One who desires
to take the world
and act (wei)
upon it, I see that
it cannot be
done. The world
(t'ien hsia) is a
spirit vessel
(shen ch'i),
Which cannot be
acted (wei) upon.
One who acts
(wei) on it fails,
One who holds
on to it loses
(shih)

d, Some weep,
some blow flutes,
Some become
strong, some
superfluous,
Some oppress,
some are
destroyed.
Therefore the
Sage Casts off
extremes, Casts
off excess, Casts
off
Extravagance.
up

d, While others
must lag; And
some that feel hot,
While others feel
cold; And some
that are strong,
While others are
weak; And
vigorous ones,
While others worn
out. So the Wise
Man discards
Extreme
inclinations To
make sweeping
judgments, Or to a
life of excess.

imes stop,
Sometimes be
active, Sometimes
be at rest,
Sometimes be
safe, Sometimes
be in danger. The
master knows the
world is beyond
his control, so lets
things come and
go without
interfering. He is
like a blade of
grass: When the
wind blows it
bends with it. This
way he is always
centered and
keeps his energy.
up

it. For, of all
creatures: some
lead, some
follow; some
sigh, some
complain; some
are strong, some
are weak; some
suffer setbacks,
some are already
fallen. Thus a
wise ruler avoids
extremes,
extravagance,
and excesses.
up

. Therefore
things either
move forward or
follow behind;
They blow hot or
blow cold; They
are strong
(ch'iang) or
weak; They get
on or they get off.
Therefore the
sage gets rid of
over-doing, Gets
rid of
extravagances,
Gets rid of
excesses. up

Chapter 30

Use Tao to help
rule people. This
world has no
need for
weapons, Which
soon turn on
themselves.
Where armies
camp, nettles
grow. After each
war, years of
famine. The most
fruitful outcome
Does not d

To those who
would help The
ruler of men By
means of the Way:
Let him not with
his militant might
Try to conquer the
world; This tactic is
like to recoil. For
where armies have
marched, There do
briars spring up;
Where great hosts
are impressed,
Years of hunger
and evil ensue.
The good man's
purpose once
attained, He stops

A father who
trusts in the Tao
doesn't force his
children to do
anything, and
doesn't discipline
them. He knows
this would be
against the
natural way and
would damage
the children as
well as himself.
The master
knows if force is
used on a c

He who assists a
ruler through Tao,
Disavows
dominating the
world by military
force. The effects
of using force are
immediate:
Wherever the
army is stationed,
briars and thorns
will grow. (After a
big war, years of
famine will surely
follow.) The best
leader cares only
about an
accommodation,
and Dare

One who assists
the ruler with Tao,
Does not
overpower
(ch'iang) the world
by military
conquests. Such
affairs have a way
of returning
(huan): Where
armies are
stationed, Briars
and thorns grow,
After great
campaigns, Bad
years are sure to
follow. The good
person is resolute
(kuo) only, But
dares not (kan)
take the path of
the

epend on force,
But succeeds
without
arrogance
Without hostility
Without Pride
Without
resistance
Without violence.
If these things
prosper and
grow old, This is
called not-Tao.
Not-Tao soon
ends. up

at that; He will not
press for victory.
His point once
made, he does not
boast, Or
celebrate the goal
he gained, Or
proudly indicate
the spoils. He won
the day because
he must: But not
by force or
violence. That
things with age
decline in strength,
You well may say,
suits not the Way;
And not to suit the
Way is early
death.

hild, weeds will
grow in the
child's mind.
Achievements
may be
apparent, but he
will not boast or
take pride in
them. He knows
they are
attributed to the
Tao, and no
claimant exists.
From here he
simply moves on.
This is the
natural way. up

s not to gain
dominance by
force. An
accommodation
reached without
conceit, brag, or
arrogance; but on
account of no
better alternative
and reluctance of
using force.
Everything decays
after its prime,
This (using force)
would be counter
to Tao. Whoever
acts counter to
Tao leads to his
early demise. up

strong (ch'iang).
Be resolute (kuo)
yet do not boast
(ching), Be
resolute yet do not
show off (fa), Be
resolute yet do not
be haughty, Be
resolute because
you have no
choice, Be
resolute yet do not
overpower
(ch'iang). When
things are full
grown, they age.
This is called not
following Tao. Not
following Tao they
perish early. up

Chapter 31

Fine weapons are
ill-omened tools.
They are hated.
Therefore the old
Tao ignores them.
At home, honour
the left. In war,
honor the right.
Good omens
honour the left.
Bad omens honour
the right. The
lieutenant on the
left, The general
on the right As in
funeral
ceremonies.
Weapons are
ill-omened, Not
proper
instruments. Wh

Weapons
generate fear;
real humans
loath them.
Peace is the
highest value. If
it has been
destroyed,
utmost restraint
is needed to
restore it. Your
enemies are
people as well,
so any battle is
entered into
gravely.

Weapons are tools
of bad omen,
everyone dislikes
them, Thus the
follower of Tao
keeps away from
them. A statesman
normally honours
his left; But in war,
he honours his
right. Weapons are
tools of bad omen,
and of no use to a
statesman. If
forced to use
them, it is best for
him to be calm and
restrained. Glorify
not the victory of
war. One who
does, must be
happy to kill! He
who is h

en their use can't
be avoided, Calm
restraint is best.
Don't think they
are beautiful.
Those who think
they are beautiful
Rejoice in killing
people. Those who
rejoice in killing
people Cannot
achieve their
purpose in this
world. When many
people are killed
We feel sorrow
and grief. A great
victory Is a funeral
ceremony. up

Do not wish them
personal harm.
Do not rejoice in
victory. Who
would rejoice in
the killing of
men? Conduct a
war as you would
a funeral, it is a
time of mourning.
Weep for your
enemy as you
would for your
friend. up

appy to kill must
not succeed in the
world. Auspicious
occasions honour
the left, Evil
occasions honour
the right. When the
deputy general
stays on the left,
While the full
general stays on
the right, Declare
that a funeral
ceremony is taking
place. Since so
many people are
slaughtered, Let
us weep with deep
sorrow and grief,
and Treat a victory
celebration as a
funeral ceremony.
up

Chapter 32

Tao endures
without a name.
Though simple
and slight, No
one under
heaven can
master it. If kings
and lords could
posses it, All
beings would
become their
guests. Heaven
and earth
together Would
drip sweet dew
Equa

The Way eternal
has no name. A
block of wood
untooled, though
small, May still
excel the world.
And if the king and
nobles could
Retain its potency
for good, Then
everything would
freely give
Allegiance to their
rule. The earth and
sky would then
conspire To bring
the sweet dew

The Tao is not big,
but it contains all.
If a father could
follow the Tao, the
children will be
naturally
compliant.
Everything will be
in perfect accord,
and life will be
sweet. If you
create laws, you
create
lawlessness. If you
trust the people
the law will be
written on

Tao is eternal and
nameless. Even
though its singular
building block is
tiny, None in the
world can master
over it. If kings and
barons keep faith
in it, All things
spontaneously
follow order. When
Heaven and Earth
joined to make
sweet dew, It is
evenly sp

Tao everlasting
(ch'ang) is the
nameless
uncarved wood
(p'u). Though
small, Nothing
under heaven can
subjugate it (mo
neng ch'en). If
kings and barons
can abide by
(shou) it, All
creatures will
arrive as guests
(pin) to a banquet.
Heaven and earth
unite, To send
down the sweet
rain. Without being
commanded b

lly on all people
Without
regulation. Begin
to make order
and names arise.
Names lead to
more names -
And to knowing
when to stop.
Tao's presence
in this world Is
like valley
streams Flowing
into rivers and
seas. up

down; And evenly
it would be given
To folk without
constraining
power. Creatures
came to be with
order's birth, And
once they had
appeared, Came
also knowledge of
repose, And with
that was security.
In this world,
Compare those of
the Way To
torrents that flow
Into river and sea.

their hearts. When
you name
something, you
create division.
Institutions are
created to serve a
common purpose.
When the purpose
is served they are
no longer needed.
Know when to stop
to avoid conflicts.
Everything flows
into the Tao, as all
rivers flow into the
ocean. up

read without the
people's
command.
Initiating
regulations
produces names.
Since names
already proliferate,
one must also
know when to
stop. Knowing
when to stop can
avoid over
regulation. Tao to
the world is like
streams in valleys
to the rivers and
sea. up

y the people (mo
chih ling), It falls
evenly (chün) by
itself. At the
beginning of
institution names
come to be. Once
there are names,
One must know
when to stop (chih
chih). One who
knows when to
stop does not
become exhausted
(pu tai). Tao in the
world is like Valley
streams flowing
into rivers and
seas. up

Chapter 33

Knowing others
is intelligent.
Knowing yourself
is enlightened.
Conquering
others takes
force.
Conquering
yourself is true
strength.
Knowing what i

It is wisdom to
know others; It is
enlightenment to
know one's self.
The conqueror of
men is powerful;
The master of
himself is strong.
It i

With intellect,
you have
knowledge of
others.
Enlightened
there is no self.
With force you
can master
others. By
yielding you
master the Tao.
In striving to
accumul

He who
understands
others is
intelligent; He
who knows
himself is wise.
He who wins
over others is
persuasive; He
who conquers
himself is strong.
He who fe

One who knows
(chih) others is
knowledgeable
(chih); One who
knows (chih) the
self is
enlightened
(ming). One who
overcomes
others has
physical might;
One who
overcomes the
self (tzu sheng)
is strong
(ch'iang)

s enough is
wealth. Forging
ahead shows
inner resolve.
Hold your ground
and you will last
long. Die without
perishing and
your life will
endure. up

s wealth to be
content; It is
willful to force
one's way on
others.
Endurance is to
keep one's place;
Long life it is to
die and not
perish.

ate wealth, you
become poor. In
accepting what
you have, you
become rich. Do
only what needs
to be done and
relax. If you
accept death,
you will live in
eternity. up

els contented is
rich; He who acts
forcefully is
determined. He
who does not
lose his center
endures; He who
dies but is not
forgotten enjoys
long life. up

. One who knows
contentment
(chih tsu) is rich;
One who acts
strongly (ch'iang)
has will power
(chih). One who
does not lose
where one
belongs lasts
long; One who
dies without
perishing (wang)
has longevity. up

Chapter 34

Great Tao
overflows. To the
left To the right.
All beings owe
their life to it And
do not depart
from it. It acts
without a name.
It clothes and
nourishes all
beings But does
not become their
mast

O the great Way
o'erflows And
spreads on every
side! All beings
come from it; No
creature is
denied. But
having called
them forth, It
calls not one its
own. It feeds and
clothes them all
And will not be
their lord.
Without desire
always, It seems

The Tao flows
constantly like a
river. All things
arise in it, but are
not separate. It
brings about the
natural sequence
of things, but
makes no effort.
It nourishes the
whole universe,
but claims

How the great
Tao flows
everywhere! All
things depend on
it for life and it
never turns away
from them; It
completes the
work
successfully
without seeking
recognition; It
protects and
nurtures all
things without
becoming their

The great Tao
floods over, To
the left, to the
right. Ten
thousand beings
live by it, And it
does not reject
them. Work is
accomplished
(ch'eng), yet it
has no name. It
clothes and
nourishes ten
thousand beings,
But does not lord
over them. Al

er. Enduring
without desires,
It may be called
slight. All beings
return to it, But it
does not become
their master. It
may be called
immense. By not
making itself
great, It can do
great things. up

of slight import.
Yet, nonetheless,
in this Its
greatness still
appears: When
they return to it,
No creature
meets a lord.
The Wise Man,
therefore, while
he is alive, Will
never make a
show of being
great: And that is
how his
greatness is
achieved.

no reward.
Everything relies
on it, but it does
not rely on
anything. All
things come and
go, but it alone
is; that is its
greatness. It has
no desire to be
great, so its
greatness is
complete. up

master. Always
devoid of desire
may be an
insignificant
accomplishment;
All things follow it
without
becoming their
master has to be
a great
accomplishment.
Just because it
has no desire to
be great, It can
achieve
greatness. up

ways without
desire, It may be
named the small;
Ten thousand
beings return
(kuei) to it, Yet it
does not lord
over them, It may
be named the
great. Because it
never considers
itself great,
Therefore it can
accomplish
(ch'eng) its
greatness. up

Chapter 35

Hold the great
elephant - The
great image -
And the world
moves. Moves
without danger in
safety and
peace. Music
and sweets
Make passing
guest

Once grasp the
great Form
without form,
And you roam
where you will
With no evil to
fear, Calm,
peaceful, at
ease. At music
and viands The
wayfarer

The master
being at one with
the Tao doesn't
feel threatened
when in danger.
Even if
surrounded by
misery he is
perfectly
peaceful. People
are excited by
the sound of
music or the
taste of food. B

Whoever has a
firm hold on the
big form, The
entire world will
follow him. They
will experience
no harm, But
security, peace
and comfort.
Having food and
m

Hold aloft the
Great Image
(hsiang), The
whole world will
go to it. Going to
it, they will meet
with no harm,
Only safety,
peace, and
contentment (an
p'ing t'ai). When
music and dainty
dishes are
offered, The
passe

s pause. But the
Tao emerges
Flavourless and
bland. Look - you
won't see it.
Listen - You
won't hear it. Use
it - You will never
use it up. up

stops. But the
Way, when
declared, Seems
thin and so
flavorless! It is
nothing to look at
And nothing to
hear; But used, it
will prove
Inexhaustible.

ut they find
words which try
to point out the
Tao flavourless.
If you try to look
for it, it cannot be
seen. If you try to
listen for it, it
cannot be heard.
Experience it,
and it never
ceases. up

usic, Even
passers-by stop.
Talking about
Tao is tasteless
and plain. And it
is: Invisible by
looking;
Inaudible by
listening and
Inexhaustible by
using. up

rs-by stop. Tao,
when it is uttered
by the mouth, Is
so bland it has
no flavor. When
looked at, it is not
enough to be
seen. When
listened to, it is
not enough to be
heard, When
used (yung), it is
inexhaustible. up

Chapter 36

To collect, first scatter. To Weaken, first strengthen. To abolish, first establish. To conclude, first initiate. This is called subtle il

What is to be shrunken Is first stretched out; What is to be weakened Is first made strong; What will be thrown over Is first raised up; What will be withdrawn Is first bestow

For something to expand, first it must shrink. To strengthen something, first it must be weakened. To raise something, first it must be lowered. To receive something, first you must

In order to contract it, first allow it to expand. In order to weaken it, first allow it to strengthen; In order to eliminate it, first allow it to grow; In order to take away from it, first allow i

What is to be reduced, Must first be expanded. What is to be weakened, Must first be made strong (ch'iang). What is to be abolished, Must first be established. What is to be taken away, Must first b

lumination. Soft and weak overcome stiff and strong. Fish cannot escape the deep pool. A country's sharpest weapons Cannot be displayed. up

ed. This indeed is Subtle Light; The gentle way Will overcome The hard and strong. As fish should not Get out of pools, The realm's edged tools Should not be shown To anybody.

give. This subtlety can be seen in all matters. The soft overcomes the hard. The subtle penetrates the obvious. Keep your inner development a secret, and the results will be clear. up

t to receive. These are called common sense which includes: The soft and weak overcome the hard and strong; A fish should not leave deep water; State's sharp weapons should not be shown to others. up

e given. This is called the subtle illumination (wei ming). The soft and weak overcome the hard and strong. Fish must not leave the stream. Sharp weapons (ch'i) of a state, Must not be displayed. up

Chapter 37

Tao endures
without a name,
Yet nothing is left
undone. If kings
and lords could
possess it, All
beings would
transform
themselves.
Transformed, t

The Way is
always still, at
rest, And yet
does everything
that's done. If
then the king and
nobles could
Retain its
potency for good,
The creatures all
would be
transformed. But
if, the change
once made in
them, Th

The Tao never
does anything,
yet there is
nothing it doesn't
do. If a father
instills this virtue
into his being,
the children will
be transformed
by themselves, in

Tao forever
takes no action
but nothing is left
undone. If
barons and kings
were able to
keep faith in it,
All things will
transform
spontaneously
on their own.
Should selfish
desires arise
anew, I shall
counter them
with

Tao everlasting
(ch'ang) does not
act (wu wei), And
yet nothing is not
done (erh wu pu
wei). If kings and
barons can abide
by (shou) it, The
ten thousand
things will
transform by
themselves (tzu
hua). If in
transforming
desire (yü

hey desire to
create; I quiet
them through
nameless
simplicity. Then
there is no
desire. No desire
is serenity, An
the world settles
of itself. up

ey still inclined to
do their work, I
should restrain
them then By
means of that
unique Original
simplicity Found
in the Virgin
Block, Which
brings
disinterest, With
stillness in its
train, And so, an
ordered world.

accordance with
their nature.
Following their
nature, their
contentment is
total and no
desires would
arise. When no
desire arises,
bliss and
tranquility abide.
up

natural goodness
yet unnamed.
What the
unnamed natural
goodness brings,
Is but the
riddance of
selfish desires.
Riddance of
selfish desires
will bring forth
tranquility, Then
peace would
naturally prevail
in the world. up

) is aroused, I
shall suppress it
by the nameless
uncarved wood
(p'u). With the
nameless
uncarved wood,
There shall be no
desire (wu yü).
Without desire
there is thus
quietude (ching).
The world shall
be self-ordered
(tzu ting). up

Chapter 38

High Te? No Te!
That's what Te is.
Low Te doesn't
lack Te; That's
what Te is not.
Those highest in
Te take no action
And don't need to
act. Those lowest in
Te take action And
do need to act.
Those highest in
benevolence take
action But don't
need to act. Those
highest in
righteousness take
action And do
need to act. Those
highest in propriety
take action And if
people don't
reciprocate Roll up
their sle

The master needs
no satisfaction, so
his acts are always
pure. An ordinary
man demands
satisfaction, so his
acts are always
tainted. The
master is not a
doer, so nothing is
to be done. An
ordinary man is a
doer, so many
things need doing.
A man who tries to
do the right thing
creates more
problems. A man
who tries to do the
moral thing will
use force. If
people can't act
naturally, they may
try to be good. If
they can't be go

Chapter 39

The Tao is not separate from mind, body and spirit. But mind, body and spirit can separate from the Tao. A clear mind and you are as open as the sky. A healthy body and you are as vital as the earth. A free spirit and you are bound to nothing. A mind which is divided by thoughts lacks clarity. A body wh

ich indulges the senses becomes ill. A spirit which is chained to the world will break. The master serves his mind, body and spirit all they require, and asks not a thing in return. With no will of his own, the Tao leads him to an unknown destination. How could this not be the greatest journey of man? up

Chapter 40

Reversal is Tao's movement.
Yielding is Tao's practice. All th

The movement of the Way is a return; In weakness lies its major usefulness. From Wh

All things return to the Tao. The Tao yields to receive them all. Ev

Tao moves in cycles. Tao uses the soft and weak to reveal the truth. All things in the w

Returning (fan) is the movement (tung) of Tao. Weak (jo) is the functioning (yung) of Tao.

ings originate from being.
Being originates from non-being.
up

at-is all the world of things was born But What-is sprang in turn from What-is-not.

everything appears to be something. Something arises out of nothing. up

orld are born from being, and Being (the named) is born from non-being (the unnamed).
up

Ten thousand things under heaven are born of being (yu). Being is born of non-being (wu).
up

Chapter 41

The great scholar
hearing the Tao
Tries to practice it.
The middling
scholar hearing
the Tao,
Sometimes has it,
sometimes not.
The lesser scholar
hearing the Tao
Has a good laugh.
Without that
laughter It wouldn't
be Tao. Therefore
these sayings: The
bright road seems
dark, The road
forward sees to
retreat, The level
road seems ro

On hearing of the
Way, the best of
men Will earnestly
explore its length.
The mediocre
person learns of it
And takes it up
and sets it down.
But vulgar people,
when they hear
the news, Will
laugh out loud,
and if they did not
laugh, It would not
be the Way. And
so there is a
proverb: "When
going looks like
coming back, The
clearest road is
mighty dark."
Today, the Way
that's plai

One, who upon
hearing of the Tao
is immediately
transformed, is
superior. One, who
upon hearing of
the Tao, half
doubts it, is
average. One, who
upon hearing of
the Tao laughs at
it, is inferior. If
fools didn't scoff at
it, it wouldn't be
great. Thus it is
said: Light seems
to arise out

When Tao is heard
by a man of high
intellect, He
practices it with
diligence. When
Tao is heard by a
man of average
intellect, He
follows it
half-heartedly.
When Tao is heard
by a man of no
intellect, He will
have a hearty
laugh at it. And it
would not be Tao
without being
laughed at. Thus
there is the
accepted saying:
The bright way
appears dark; the
progressive way,
regressive; and
the smooth way, u

ugh. Great Te
seems hollow.
Great purity seems
sullied. Pervasive
Te sees deficient.
Established Te
seems furtive.
Simple truths
seem to change.
The great square
has no corners.
The great vessel is
finished late. The
great sound is
scarcely voiced.
The great image
has no form. Tao
hides, no name.
Yet Tao alone gets
things done. up

n looks rough, And
lofty virtue like a
chasm; The purest
innocence like
shame, The
broadest power
not enough,
Established
goodness knavery,
Substantial worth
like shifting tides.
Great space has
no corners; Great
powers come late;
Great music is soft
sound; The great
Form no shape.
The Way is
obscure and
unnamed; It is a
skilled investor,
nonetheless, The
master of
accomplishment.

of darkness. To go
forward appears to
be going in
reverse. To be
simple seems
complicated. Real
compassion
seems harsh. Real
strength seems
weak. The
unchanged seems
to change. Great
love seems
indifferent. The
master seems like
a fool. The Tao is
nothing, but
through it
everything is. up

neven. The high
virtue appears
hollow; the purest
white, tinted; the
far-reaching virtue,
inadequate; the
firm virtue, lax; and
the real quality,
wanting. The
greatest square
appears
cornerless; the
great talent, the
last to be
recognized; the
great music,
devoid of
appealing sound;
and the great
image, formless.
Tao is hidden and
nameless, Yet only
Tao is capable of
helping all to
succeed in life. up

Chapter 42

Tao engenders One, One engenders Two, Two engenders Three, Three engenders the ten thousand things. The ten thousand things carry shade And embrace sunlight. Shade and sunlight, yin and yang, Breath blending into harmony. Humans hat

The Way begot one, And the one, two; Then the two begot three And three, all else. All things bear the shade on their backs And the sun in their arms; By the blending of breath From the sun and the shade, Equilibrium comes to the world. Orphaned, or needy, or desolate, these Are conditions

The Tao gave birth to the universe. The universe gave birth to the earth. The earth gave birth to man. Man gave birth to everything. Everything is experience, but receives a name. There is total ha

Tao created the One; The One produced the Two; The two produced the Three; And the Three produced all things. All things carry the Yin (female) and embrace the Yang (male), Harmony is achieved through interaction of these prime energies. People hate to be orphans,

Tao gives birth to one, One gives birth to two, Two gives birth to three, Three gives birth to ten thousand beings. Ten thousand beings carry yin on their backs and embrace yang in their front, Blending these two vital breaths (ch'i) to attain harmony (ho). What people hate most, Are to be orphaned, widowed and u

e To be alone, poor, and hungry. Yet kings and princes Use these words as titles. We gain by losing, Lose by gaining. What others teach, I also teach: "A violent man does not die a natural death. This is the basis of my teaching. up

much feared and disliked; Yet in public address, the king And the nobles account themselves thus. So a loss sometimes benefits one Or a benefit proves to be loss. What others have taught I also shall teach: If a violent man does not come To a violent death, I shall choose him to teach me.

rmony when name and experience combine. An ordinary man seeks a name in the eyes of others, but at their expense. The master experiences for himself. A violent man will not enjoy a natural death. up

widowers, or being destitute, Yet kings and barons call themselves by these terms. Thus: One my gain by losing first, and One my lose by gaining first. What people teach I can also teach. "A violent person would not die a natural death," Shall be my first lesson. up

nworthy. Yet kings and dukes call themselves by these. Thus things are either decreased so as to be increased, Or increased (i) so as to be decreased (sun). What others teach, I also teach: "The strong and violent (ch'iang liang) do not die a natural death." This I shall hold as the father (fu) of my teaching. up

Chapter 43

The softest thing
in the world rides
roughshod over
the strongest.
No-thing enters
no-space. This
teaches me t

The softest of
stuff in the world
Penetrates
quickly the
hardest;
Insubstantial, it
enters Where no
room is. By this I
know the benefit

The softest
overcomes the
hardest, by
yielding.
Emptiness can
enter where
there is no
space. The value
of non-action

The softest thing
in the world is
galloping inside
of the hardest;
The invisible
substance is
entering media
having no space.
I therefor

The softest (chih
jou) in the world,
Gallops (ch'ih
ch'eng) in the
hardest (chih
chien) in the
world. That
which is not
penetrates that
which has no
crevice (wu yu ju
w

he benefits of
no-action.
Teaching without
words Benefit
without action -
Few in this world
can attain this.
up

Of something
done by quiet
being; In all the
world but few
can know
Accomplishment
apart from work,
Instruction when
no words are
used.

is in acting
naturally.
Therefore the
master teaches
of what is
beyond words.
And his acts
carry no
expectations. up

e learn the
benefits of taking
no action.
Lessons without
words and the
value of taking
no action, There
are few rivals in
the world. up

u chien). I
thereby know the
benefit of
no-action
(wu-wei). The
teaching without
words, The
benefit of
no-action, Hardly
anything in the
world can
compare with
them. up

Chapter 44

Name or body:
which is closer?
Body or
possessions:
which means
more? Gain or
loss: Which one
hurts? Extreme
love exacts a
great price. Many
p

Which is dearer,
fame or self?
Which is worth
more, man or
pelf? Which
would hurt more,
gain or loss? The
mean man pays
the highest p

Is fame more
important than
living? Is money
more important
than happiness?
What do you
consider success
or failure? Fame
fulfils

Fame or life,
which is more
precious? Life or
wealth, which is
more important?
Gain or loss,
which is more
harmful? An
obsession for
possession is
doomed to be
costly; An e

Your name and
your body
(shen), which is
dearer? Your
body and
material goods,
which is more
abundant? Gain
and loss, which
is illness?
Therefore in
excessive love
one necessarily
goes to great
expens

ossessions entail
a heavy loss.
Know what is
enough - Abuse
nothing. Know
when to stop -
Harm nothing.
This is how to
last for a long
time. up

rice; The hoarder
takes the
greatest loss; A
man content is
never shamed,
And
self-restrained, is
not in danger: He
will live forever.

the lives of
others.
Happiness
cannot be
bought. Living is
a celebration of
the way things
are. Happiness is
wanting no more.
up

xcessive
hoarding for
profits is sure to
incur heavy
losses. He who
is contented
loses no honour;
He who knows
when to stop
encounters no
danger; He can
thus long endure.
up

es, In hoarding
much one
necessarily loses
heavily. Knowing
contentment
(chih tsu) one
does not suffer
disgrace,
Knowing when to
stop one does
not become
exhausted (tai).
This way one
may last long. up

Chapter 45

Great accomplishment seems unfinished But its use is continuous. Great fullness seems empty But in use is inexhaustible. Great straightness seems

Most perfect, yet it seems Imperfect, incomplete: Its use is not impaired. Filled up, and yet it seems Poured out, an empty void: It never will run dry. The straightest, yet it seems To deviate, to bend; T

Although things appear imperfect, herein lies their perfection. Fullness appears empty, herein lies its fullness. That which is straight appears bent.

A perfect tool appears defective, but, it shows no impairment in operation. A great abundance appears empty, but, it is inexhaustible in consumption. A truly straight edge appears crooked,

Great perfection appears lacking (ch'üeh), Its use is unending. Great fullness appears empty, Its use is inexhaustible. Great straightness appears bent, Great ingenuity (ch'iao) appears crude, Great eloque

bent, Great skill seems clumsy, Great eloquence seems mute. Exertion overcomes cold. Calm overcomes heat. Pure calm is the norm under heaven. up

he highest skill and yet It looks like clumsiness. The utmost eloquence, It sounds like stammering. As movement overcomes The cold, and stillness, heat, The Wise Man, pure and still, Will rectify the world.

The wise appear foolish. The talented appear unskilled. That which is still appears to move. By not moving, the master can move into any situation. up

A great cleverness appears clumsy, A great orator appears tight tongued. Vigorous exercise overcomes cold; Calm quietude overcomes heat. Clear heads and calm minds can right the world. up

nce (píen) appears inarticulate. When agitation (tsao) wins (sheng), the cold arrives, When tranquillity (ching) wins (sheng), the hot arrives. Clear and tranquil the world is in the right mode (cheng). up

Chapter 46

With Tao under
heaven Stray
horses fertilize
the fields.
Without Tao
under heaven
Warhorses are
bred at the
frontier. There is
no greater
calamity

When the Way
rules the world,
Coach horses
fertilize the fields;
When the Way
does not rule,
War horses
breed in the
parks. No sin can
exceed
Incitement to

With the Tao,
everything
serves a natural
creative function.
With man,
weapons are
made to destroy.

When Tao
prevails in the
world, Horses
walk in the field
to fertilize. When
Tao is missing in
the world,
Military horses
give births in the
suburbs. No guilt
is greater than
insatiable desi

When the world
practices Tao,
Fast horses are
used for their
dung. When the
world does not
practice Tao,
War horses give
birth at the
borders. Among
offenses (tsui),
none is greater
than having what
is desirable.
Among c

Than not
knowing what is
enough. There is
no greater fault
Than desire for
success.
Therefore,
Knowing that
enough is
enough Is always
Enough. up

envy; No
calamity's worse
Than to be
discontented,
Nor is there an
omen More
dreadful than
coveting. But
once be
contented, And
truly you'll always
be so.

Desire creates
fear and
violence. Without
desire there is no
fear. Free from
fear you are
eternal. up

res; No
misfortune is
greater than
mindless
discontent; No
sin is greater
than
uncontrollable
greed. Therefore,
He who knows
the contentment
of being
contented, Will
always be
contented. up

alamities (huo),
none is greater
than not knowing
contentment.
Among blames
(chiu), none is
greater than the
desire for gain.
Therefore the
contentment that
comes from
knowing
contentment Is a
long lasting
contentment. up

Chapter 47

Without going
out the door,
Know the world.
Without peeping
through the
window, See
heaven's Tao.
The further you
trav

The world may
be known
Without leaving
the house; The
Way may be
seen Apart from
the windows.
The further you
go

You cannot go
anywhere to
experience the
Tao. It can only
be experienced
here. The more
knowledge you
have, the less
you

Without stepping
out of the door,
He knows what
the world is like.
Without looking
out of the
window, He
understands the
way of Heaven.
The farther

Without stepping
(ts'u) out the
door, Know
(chih) the world.
Without looking
out the window,
See (chien) the
Tao of Heaven.
The farther one
comes out, The
le

el, The less you
know. This is
why the Sage
Knows without
budging,
Identifies without
looking, Does
without trying. up

, The less you
will know.
Accordingly, the
Wise Man Knows
without going,
Sees without
seeing, Does
without doing.

know. The
master knows
without
knowledge, and
sees without
eyes. Without
thinking of
success is his
eternal success.
up

he travels, The
less he learns.
So the Sage:
Knows without
traveling;
Understands
situations without
seeing, and
Succeeds
without taking
action. up

ss one knows.
Therefore the
sage knows
(chih) without
travelling, Names
(ming) things
without seeing
(chien) them,
Accomplishes
(cheng) without
work (wei). up

Chapter 48

Pursue knowledge, gain daily. Pursue Tao, lose daily. Lose and again lose, Arrive at non-doing. Non-doing -

The student learns by daily increment. The Way is gained by daily loss, Loss upon loss until At last comes rest. By letting g

You learn something everyday through knowledge. You unlearn something everyday experiencing the Tao. Unlearn more and more until you know.

Pursuing learning, one needs to learn more every day. Practicing Tao, one needs to do less every day. Less and even less, one reaches a state of taking no ac

To pursue (wei) learning one increases daily. To pursue (wei) Tao one decreases daily. To decrease and again to decrease, Until one arrives at not doing (wu-wei). Not

and nothing not done. Take the entire world as nothing. Make the least effort, And the world escapes you. up

o, it all gets done; The world is won by those who let it go! But when you try and try, The world is then beyond the winning.

Then there is no doer, thus nothing to do. Doing nothing, let things take their natural course. Try to do something and you will miss. up

tion. Taking no action but nothing is left undone. Taking over an empire must always be a nonevent. If eventful, it is unworthy of taking over the empire. up

doing (wu-wei) and yet nothing is not done. Always take the empire when there are no businesses. If there are businesses, It is not worthwhile to take the empire. up

Chapter 49

The Sage has no set heart.
Ordinary people's hearts
Become the Sage's heart.
People who are good I treat well.
People who are not good I also treat well: Te as goodness.
Trustworthy people I trust.
Untrust

The Wise Man's mind is free But
tuned to people's need: "Alike to be good and bad
I must be good,
For Virtue is goodness. To honest folk And those dishonest ones Alike, I proffer faith, For Vir

The master has no fixed ideas, but accepts whatever comes his way. His is an unbending trust in existence, so he treats all the same. He trusts that a good man is doing

A wise ruler has no preconceived ideas, He adopts the people's ideas as his own. I treat good people with goodness, I treat bad people also with goodness. This is the virtue of goodness. I deal with honest people with honesty, I deal wit

The sage has no set mind (ch'ang hsin), He takes the mind of the people as his mind. The good (shan) I am good to them, The not good I am also good to them. This is the goodness of nature (te). The trustworthy (hsin) I trust

worthy people I also trust. Te as trust. Sages create harmony under heaven Blending their hearts with the world. Ordinary people fix their eyes and ears upon them, But Sages become the world's children. up

tue is faithful." The Wise Man, when abroad, Impartial to the world, Does not divide or judge. But people everywhere Mark well his ears and eyes; For wise men hear and see As little children do.

the right thing. He also trusts that a bad man is doing the right thing. He keeps his trust a secret, knowing others cannot understand. He appears to be like a child. up

h dishonest people also with honesty. This is the virtue of honesty. For the benefit of the world, the wise ruler harmonizes all ideas. (The people pay attention to him through ears and eyes,) And he treats them all like his children. up

t them, The not trustworthy I also trust them. This is the trust of nature (te). The sage in the world, Mixes (hun) the minds (hsin) of all. The people lift up their eyes and ears, The sage treats them all like children. up

Chapter 50

Emerge into life,
enter death, Life is
only the thirteen
body parts. Death
is only the thirteen
body parts. Human
life, moving
towards death, Is
the same thirteen.
Why is this?
Because life gives
life to substance.
You have heard of
people Good at
holding

On leaving life, to
enter death:
Thirteen members
form a living body;
A corpse has
thirteen, too:
Thirteen spots by
which a man may
pass From life to
death. Why so?
Because his way
of life Is much too
gross. As I have
heard, the man
who knows On
land how best to

Ordinary people
revolve in the
misery of birth
and death. The
master is free
from birth and
death. A person
is not born of
existence, but
born of societal
conditioning.
Ordinary people
are like water
which fears th

From birth to
death, Three out of
ten follow the path
of life; Three out of
ten follow the path
of death; also
Three out of ten
who follow the
path of life may
move into path of
death. Why is
that? Because
they over strive in
their lives. I heard
that he who excels
in
self-preservation:
Mee

From coming out
to life to going
back to death:
Those companions
(t'u) of life, They
are one-third
(shih-yu-san);
Those companions
of death, They are
one-third; Those
living but moving
toward the place of
death, They are
also one-third.
Why? Because of
the intense (hou)
life-producing
activity. I have hea

on to life. Walking
overland they don't
avoid Rhinos and
tigers. In battle
they don't arm
themselves. The
rhino's horn find
nothing to gore;
The tiger's claws
find nothing to flay,
Weapons find
nothing to pierce.
Why is this? They
have no mortal
spot. up

be at peace Will
never meet a tiger
or a buffalo; In
battle, weapons do
not touch his skin.
There is no place
the tiger's claws
can grip; Or with
his horn, the
buffalo can jab; Or
where the soldier
can insert his
sword. Why so? In
him there is no
place of death.

e death of
freezing. The
master is like
H2O and
welcomes the
movement of one
state to another
as the natural
course of things.
Because he
accepts death,
he is always
safe. Wild beasts
or weapons
cannot harm him.
up

ts no tiger or
rhinoceros while
walking on land;
Escapes harm
while fighting in
wars. And he
encounters: No
rhinoceros butting
its horn against
him; No tiger
exerting its claws
against him; No
soldier thrusting
his knife against
him. Why is this
so? Because he is
not on the path of
death. up

rd that one who
knows how to
nourish life, On
land meets no
tigers or wild
buffaloes, In battle
needs to wear no
armors or
weapons, A wild
buffalo has
nowhere to butt its
horns, A tiger has
nowhere to sink its
claws, A weapon
has nowhere to
enter its blade.
Why? Because
such a one has no
place of death. up

Chapter 51

Tao bears them
Te nurses them
Events form
them Energy
completes them.
Therefore the ten
thousand beings
Honour Tao and
respect Te. Tao
is honoured Te is
respected
Because they do
not give orders
But endure in
their own nature.
Therefore, Tao b

The Way brings
forth, Its virtue
fosters them, With
matter they take
shape, And
circumstance
perfects them all:
That is why all
things Do honor
the Way And
venerate its power.
The exaltation of
the Way, The
veneration of its
power, Come not
by fate or decree;
But always just
because By nature

For every being,
the Tao is.
Conscious
existence comes
naturally.
Physical
appearance is
determined by
circumstances.
Therefore, the
Tao is honoured
by all without
effort. All are
born of it, and it
provides their
livelihood

Tao creates all
things, Virtue
nurtures them.
Matter gives them
forms, and
Environment
allows them to
succeed. Thus all
things honour Tao
and value Virtue.
Tao being
honoured and
Virtue being
valued, They
always occurred
naturally without
being dictated by
anyone.

Tao gives birth,
Te rears (hsü),
Things (wu)
shape,
Circumstances
(shih) complete.
Therefore the ten
thousand things,
None do not
respect Tao and
treasure te. Tao
is respected, Te
is treasured, Not
by decree
(ming), But by
spontaneity (t

ears them and
Te nurses them,
Rears them,
Raises them,
Shelters them,
Nurtures them,
Supports them,
Protects them.
Bears them
without owning
them, Helps
them without
coddling them,
Rears them
without ruling
them. This is
called original
Te. up

it is so. So when
the Way brings
forth, Its power
fosters all: They
grow, are reared,
And fed and
housed until They
come to ripe
maturity. You shall
give life to things
But never possess
them; Your work
shall depend on
none; You shall be
chief but never
lord. This
describes the
mystic power.

d. It is the safe
haven of life and
the destination of
death. It
produces
everything, but
possesses
nothing. Through
it all
opportunities
arise, but it isn't
involved. Its
virtue is total,
and its function is
mysterious. up

Thus: Tao creates
all thing. Virtue
nurtures them:
They grow and
develop; Bear
fruits and mature;
and Are cared for
and protected. To
create, but not to
possess; To care
for, but not to
control; To lead,
but not to
subjugate. This is
called the
profound virtue. up

zu-jan).
Therefore Tao
gives birth, Te
keeps, grows,
nurtures,
matures, ripens,
covers and
buries. To give
birth without
possession, To
act (wei) without
holding on to, To
grow (chang)
without lording
over, This is
called the dark
te. up

Chapter 52

The world has a source: the world's mother. Once you have the mother, You know the children. Once you know the children, Return to the mother. Your body dies. There is no danger. Block the passage, Bolt the gate: No strain Until your life ends. Open the

It began with a matrix: The world had a mother Whose sons can be known As ever, by her. But if you know them, You'll keep close to her As long as you live And suffer no harm. Stop up your senses; Close up your doors; Be not exhausted As long as you live. Open your senses; Be bu

Everything begins with the Tao and ends with the Tao. To know it retrace the steps of your life. When you reach back to the beginning, the Tao lies herein. Then you will realise there is no death. Without d

The world had its beginning, Which is known as the mother of the world. Once the mother is known, her sons may be understood. Once the sons are understood, still keep to the mother. Then you will avoid mistakes all your life. Close your apertures, shut your doors, You will live a life without toil; Open

The world (t'ien hsia) has an origin (shih), Which is the world's (t'ien hsia) mother (mu). Having reached the mother, (We) know her child. Having known the child, Return and abide by its mother. (In this way) one loses the body without becoming exhausted. Stop the apertures (tui), Close the doors, (In this way) one's whole life (shen) is without toil (c

passage, Take charge of things No relief Until your life ends. Seeing the small is called brightness Maintaining gentleness is called strength. Use this brightness to return to brightness. Don't cling to your body's woes. Then you can learn endurance. up

sier still: To the end of your days There's no help for you. You are bright, it is said, If you see what is small; A store of small strengths Makes you strong. By the use of its light, Make your eyes again bright From evil to lead you away. This is called "practicing constancy."

esire your heart is at peace. Without judgment your mind is clear. See who it is that sees. Witness thoughts come and go. Turn the light around and find its source. Practicing this leads to enlightenment. up

your apertures, meddle in distractions, You will live a life beyond salvation. Capable of seeing details is called clear vision; Capable of yielding is called strength. Using the innate light, recover your clear vision. Then you will not be exposed to hidden danger. This is called following the nature. up

h'in). Open the apertures, Going about the affairs, (In this way) one's whole life (shen) cannot be saved. To see the small is called illumination (ming). To abide by the soft is called strength. Use the bright light (kuang), But return to the dim light (ming), Do not expose your life (shen) to perils, Such is to follow (hsi) the everlasting (ch'ang). up

Chapter 53

Having some knowledge When walking on the Great Tao Only brings fear. The great Tao is very smooth, But people like rough trails. The government is divided, Fields are overgrown, Granaries are empty

When I am walking on the mighty Way, Let me but know the very least I may, And I shall only fear to leave the road. The mighty Way is easy underfoot, But people still prefer the little paths. The royal court is dignified, sedate, While farmers' fields are overgrown wit

Freedom lies in the Tao. Habits are binding. There is freedom in moderation, and bondage in excess. When the wealthy thrive at the expense of others, is t

Grant me the subtle wisdom, that I will follow the broad way and be fearful of straying away. The broad way is flat, yet people still indulge in shortcuts. The palace is quite splendid, but The fields are quite desolate, and Th

If I have a little (chieh-jan) knowledge (chih), To walk the great path (Tao), I shall fear this: The great path (Tao) is very flat and easy, Yet others (jen) are fond of bypaths. The courts are very neat, The fields are very weedy

y,. But the nobles clothes are gorgeous, Their belts show off swords, And they are gluttons with food and drink. Personal wealth is excessive. This is called thieves' endowment, But it is not Tao. up

h weeds; The granaries are empty and yet they Are clad in rich-embroidered silken gowns. They have sharp swords suspended at their sides; With gluttony, they gorge with food and drink. It is, the people say, The boastfulness of brigandage, But surely not the Way!

his not theft? Is it not chaotic for a rich man to flaunt his money, when those around have barely enough? The violence of excess will end in disaster. up

e granaries quite empty. (The rulers are) Wearing beautiful clothes, Carrying sharp swords, Bored of feasts, and Accumulating excessive wealth and treasures. These are chieftains of robbers, and No behaving according to Tao! up

, The granaries are very empty. Wearing embroidered clothes, Carrying sharp swords, Being surfeited with foods and drinks. To accumulate wealth and treasures in excess, This is called robbery and crime. This is not to follow Tao. up

Chapter 54

Well planted, not uprooted. Well embraced, never lost. Descendants will continue The ancestral rituals. Maintain oneself: Te becomes real. Maintain the family: Te becomes abundant. Maintain the community: Te becomes extensive. Maintain the country: Te becomes public. M

Set firm in the Way: none shall uproot you; Cherish it well and none shall estrange you; Your children's children faithful shall serve Your forebears at the altar of your house. Cultivate the Way yourself, and your Virtue will be genuine. Cultivate it in the home, and its Virtue will overflow. Cultivate it in the village, and the village will endure. Cultivate it in the realm

If you are rooted in the Tao, you cannot be moved. If you hold to the Tao, time won't pass. You endlessly abide in the virtue of the Tao. When your life isn't separate from the Tao, your true self is. When your family isn't sep

A person who excels in building does not uproot; A person who excels in embracing does not deviate; And their descendants do not interrupt ancestral worship.\ Cultivate it in an individual, his virtue is genuine; Cultivate it in a family, its virtue overflows; Cultivate it in a community, its virtues multiply; Cultivate it in a state, its virtue i

One who is well established is not uprooted, One who embraces firmly cannot be separated from, Thus sons and grandsons shall perform sacrifices without interruptions. In cultivating this in one's person, The person's te becomes genuine; In cultivating this in the family, The family's te has more to spare (yü); In cultivating this in the village, The village's te grows strong; In cult

aintain the world: Te becomes omnipresent. Therefore, Through self contemplate self, Through family contemplate family, Through community contemplate community, Through country contemplate country, Through world contemplate world. How do I know the world? Like this! up

, and the realm will flourish. Cultivate it in the world, and Virtue will be universal. Accordingly, One will be judged by the Man of the Way; Homes will be viewed through the Home of the Way; And the Village shall measure the village; And the Realm, for all realms, shall be standard; And the World, to this world, shall be heaven. How do I know the world is like this? By this.

arate, they will flower. When the earth isn't separate, it is abundant. When the universe isn't separate, it is harmonious. From an atom, to the universe, there is no inside or outside. How do I know? By hearing with my eyes. up

s abundant; Cultivate it in the world, its virtue is universal. Therefore, evaluate the virtue of: An individual on the basis of the individual; A family on the basis of the family; A community o the basis of the community; A state on the basis of the state; The world on the basis of the world. How do I know the situation of the world? By this. up

ivating this in the state, The state's te becomes abundant; In cultivating this in the world (t'ien hsia), The world's te becomes universal. Therefore observe (kuan) the person by the person, Observe the family by the family, Observe the village by the village, Observe the state by the state, Observe the world by the world. How do I know such is the case in the world? Through this. up

Chapter 55

Be filled with Te,
Like a baby:
Wasps, scorpions
and vipers Do not
sting it. Fierce
tigers do not stalk
it. Birds of prey do
not attack it.
Bones weak,
muscles soft, But
its grasp is tight. It
does not yet know
Union of male and
female, But its sex
is formed, Its vital
essence complete.
It c

Rich in virtue, like
an infant, Noxious
insects will not
sting him; Wild
beasts will not
attack his flesh
Nor birds of prey
sink claws in him.
His bones are soft,
his sinews weak,
His grip is
nonetheless
robust; Of sexual
union unaware,
His organs all
completely formed,
His vital force is at
its height. He
shouts all day,
does not

The master's
virtue is to be like
a newborn child.
Its connection to
the physical body
is weak, but its
hold on the Tao is
strong. Therefore it
is free from all
physical dangers.
It hasn't been
conditioned, so its
energy is whole. At
one with nature, it
can scream all day
and neve

The abundant
virtue of a person,
May be compared
to that of an infant:
Poisonous insects
do not sting him,
Wild beats do not
grab him, Birds of
prey do not claw
him. Though he
has weak bones
and soft sinews,
his grip is firm.
Despite his
ignorance of union
of male and
female, his organ
is often erect. This
demonstrates his
highest essence.
He cries all day
without becoming
hoarse. This
shows h

One who contains
te in fullness, Is to
be compared to an
infant. Wasps,
scorpions, and
snakes do not bite
it, Fierce beasts do
not attack it, Birds
of prey do not
pounce upon it. Its
bones weak, its
sinews tender, But
its grip is firm;
Knowing not the
union of the
female and male
animals, Yet its
organ stirs. Such
is the perfection of
its life-force
(ching). Crying all
day, yet it does not
get hoarse

an scream all day
and not get
hoarse, Its
harmony is
complete. Knowing
harmony is called
endurance.
Knowing
endurance is
called illumination.
Increasing life is
called fortune.
Mind controlling
energy is called
power. When
beings prosper
and grow old, Call
them not-Tao.
Not-Tao soon
ends. up

get hoarse: His
person is a
harmony.
Harmony
experienced is
known as
constancy;
Constancy
experienced is
called
enlightenment;
Exuberant vitality
is ominous, they
say; A bent for
vehemence is
called
aggressiveness.
That things with
age decline in
strength, You well
may say, suits not
the Way; And not
to suit the Way is
early death.

r becomes hoarse.
If you follow the
natural flow there
will be no desire.
Without desire
there is no
expectation.
Without
expectation there
is no
disappointment.
Without
disappointment
there is serenity. In
serenity abides the
true breath, which
is the gateway to
enlightenment. up

is utmost harmony
with Nature. To
know the harmony
with Nature is to
know the truth; To
know the truth is
enlightenment.
Over indulging in
life produces ill
consequences,
Ceding control of
vital energy to
emotion leads to
violence.
Everything decays
after its prime.
These (over
indulging, ceding
control to emotion)
would be counter
to Tao, Whoever
acts counter to
Tao spells his
early demise. up

. Such is the
Perfection of its
harmony (ho). To
know harmony is
to know the
everlasting
(ch'ang); To know
the everlasting is
to be illumined
(ming). To help life
along is to bring ill
portend; To use
mind (hsin) to
direct the life
breath (ch'i) is
called the strong
(ch'iang). When
things are
full-grown they
become old, It is
called not following
the Way (Tao). Not
following the Way
one dies early. up

Chapter 56

Those who know
don't talk. Those
who talk don't
know. Block the
passage Bolt the
gate Blunt the
sharp Untie the
knot Blend with
the light Become
one with the dust
- This is called

Those who know
do not talk And
talkers do not
know. Stop your
senses, Close
the doors; Let
sharp things be
blunted, Tangles
resolved, The
light tempered
And turmoil
subdued; For thi

If you know, you
don't talk. If you
talk, you don't
know. Don't
speak of the Tao.
Don't indulge
your senses.
Don't be
arrogant. Drop all
beliefs. Lose
self-importance.
Dismiss all
knowledge. Here
yo

He who knows
the truth does
not brag, He who
brags does not
know the truth.
Closing the
apertures,
Shutting the
doors, Blunting
the sharpness,
Resolving inner
conflicts,
Softening
brightness, and
Harmonizing with
the dusty world,
He is then in pr

One who knows
does not speak,
One who speaks
does not know.
Stop the
apertures, Close
the door; Blunt
the sharp, Untie
the entangled;
Harmonize the
bright, Make
identical the
dust. This is
called the
mystical iden

original unity. It
can't be
embraced It can't
be escaped, It
can't be helped It
can't be harmed,
It can't be
exalted It can't
be despised,
Therefore it is
revered under
Heaven. up

s is mystic unity
In which the
Wise Man is
moved Neither
by affection Nor
yet by
estrangement Or
profit or loss Or
honor or shame.
Accordingly, by
all the world, He
is held highest.

u reach
non-duality.
Once
enlightened, you
have no friends
or enemies. You
cannot be
rewarded or
punished. You
cannot be
honoured or
disgraced.
Detached from
self, you can be
called a real
human. up

ofound harmony
with Tao. Thus
he is no longer:
Affected by being
close to, or
Bothered by
being distant
from others;
Touched by
gains, or
Influenced by
losses Tempted
by nobleness, or
Shamed by
lowliness.
Therefore he is
respected by the
world. up

tity (hsüan t'ung).
Therefore with
this person you
cannot get
intimate (ch'in),
Cannot get
distant, Cannot
benefit, Cannot
harm, Cannot
exalt, Cannot
humiliate.
Therefore such
person is the
exalted of the
world. up

Chapter 57

Use the unexpected to govern the country, Use surprise to wage war, Use non-action to win the world. How do I know? Like this! The more prohibitions and rules, The poorer people become. The sharper people's weapons, The more they riot. The more skilled their techniques, The more grotesque t

"Govern the realm by the right, And battles by stratagem." The world is won by refraining. How do I know this is so? By this: As taboos increase, people grow poorer; When weapons abound, the state grows chaotic; Where skills multiply, novelties

To be a good father, you must follow the natural way. There can be no static ideas. The children are allowed to follow their own course. The more rules you have, the less they will obey. The more punishment you give, the less happy they will be. The more you interfere, the less se

Govern a state by fair rules. Conduct military operations by surprise strategies. Take over an empire as a nonevent. How do I know these should be so? Because: The more prohibitions proliferate, the poorer the people; The more sharp weapons people possess, the more chaotic the state; The more cunning people become, the more abnormal the s

heir works. The more elaborate the laws, The more they commit crimes. Therefore the Sage says, I do nothing And people transform themselves. I enjoy serenity And people govern themselves. I cultivate emptiness And people become prosperous. I have no desires And people simplify themselves. up

flourish; As statutes increase, more criminals start. So the Wise Man will say: As I refrain, the people will reform: Since I like quiet, they will keep order; When I forebear, the people will prosper; When I want nothing, they will be honest.

If-reliant they are. Therefore a master says: I do not create rules and the children act truthfully. I do not punish, and the children are happy. I do not interfere, and the children develop naturally. If a father has no desires for his children, their fulfilment is guaranteed. up

ociety; The more laws promulgate, the more robbers and thieves appear. Thus a wise ruler says: I take no action, the people are naturally peaceful; I love tranquility, the people naturally become orderly; I plan no wasteful event, the people naturally grow prosperous; I entertain no desire, the people naturally remain simple and honest. up

Chapter 58

If government is muted and muffled People are cool and refreshed. If government investigates and intrudes, People are worn down and hopeless. Bad fortune rests upon good fortune. Good luck hides within bad luck. Who knows how it will end? If ther

Listlessly govern: Happy your people; Govern exactly: Restless your people. "Bad fortune will Promote the good; Good fortune, too, Gives rise to the bad." But who can know to what that leads? For it is wrong and would assign To right t

A father that is understanding and kind has children who are honest and content. A father that is strict and harsh has children who are deceitful and cunning. The higher the standard a farther expects, the lower the results for the child. Try

When a ruler is tolerant and understanding, The people will be loyal and obedient; When a ruler is intolerant and overbearing, The people will be resentful and resistant. There are misfortunes wherein clues of blessings lie; There are blessings wherein seeds of misfortunes hide. Who woul

When the government (cheng) is dull, Its people are wholesome; When the government is efficient (ch'a), Its people are deficient (ch'üeh). Calamities (huo) are what blessings depend on, In blessings are latent calamities (huo). Who knows where is the turning point (chi)? Because there is no longer the normal (

e is no principle Principle reverts to disorder, Good reverts to calamity, People's confusion hardens and lingers on. Therefore the Sage squares without cutting, Corners without dividing, Straightens without extending, Shines without dazzling. up

he strangest derivations And would mean that goodness Is produced by magic means! Has man thus been so long astray? Accordingly, the Wise Man Is square but not sharp, Honest but not malign, Straight but not severe, Bright but not dazzling.

to make a child happy and you will bring about his misery. Force morals on a child, and he will become immoral. Realise that every coin has two sides. All a father can do is set an example which he would be happy for his children to mimic. up

d know the final outcome? There is no rule to go by! Normalcy reverts to chaos; Good reverts to evil. People have puzzled over these for a long time! Therefore a wise ruler is: Square but not cutting, Sharp but not piercing, Straight but not stretching and Illustrious but not dazzling. up

cheng), The normal reverts and appears as the strange (ch'i), The good reverts and appears as the uncanny. Rulers (jen) have lost their way, For a long stretch of days. Therefore the sage is square but not cutting (ko), Sharp but not injurious, Straight but not overreaching, Bright (kuang) but not dazzling. up

Chapter 59

Governing people and serving heaven is like living off the land. Living sparingly and responding quickly means accumulating Te. There is nothing that cannot be overcome. There is

"For ruling men or serving God, There's nothing else like stores saved up." By "stores saved up" is meant forehandedness, Accumulate Virtue, such that nothing can resist it and its limit None can guess: such infinite

A father who is moderate is able to be a genuine support. Because he doesn't consider himself, his acts are full of virtue. Having no vision of the future, he i

Governing the people or interacting with Nature, Nothing is more important than being frugal. Only being frugal can one be prepared for the future. Early preparation emphasizes heavy conservation of resources. Emphas

In governing people and serving heaven, Nothing is better than being sparing (se). Being sparing, Is called early adherence [to Tao]. Adhering early, Is called being heavy with accumulated te (chung chi te). To be heavy with accumulated te, Then [such a person is] all overc

no limit. You can become the country And the country's mother, and nourish and extend it. This is called deep roots, firm base. This is the Tao of living long and seeing far. up

resource Allows the jurisdiction of the king; Whose kingdom then will long endure If it provides the Mother an abode. Indeed it is the deeply rooted base, The firm foundation of the Way To immortality of self and name.

s totally present. Without fixed ideas, he can fit perfectly to any situation. The master has no self, therefore knows no limits. Even death cannot stop him. up

izing conservation assures no obstacles in the future. No future obstacle, then the prospect knows no limit. Knowing of no limit, a state is well prepared. Govern the state with this principle, It will long endure. up

oming. Being all overcoming, Then there is no knowing the limit (chi). Not knowing the limit, One may rule a state. Having the mother of a state, It may last long. This is called being deeply rooted and firmly founded, The way to long life and enduring vision (chiu shih). up

Chapter 60

Govern big countries Like you cook a little fish. When Tao harmonizes the world, Demons lose their power. Not that demons lose their power, but their power

Rule a large country As small fish are cooked. The evil spirits of the world Lose sanction as divinities When government proceeds According to the Way; But even if they do not lose Their ghostly countenance and right, They

In fathering, care must be taken not to spoil a child. If you give more than is asked, this is excessive. When you follow the natural way, good or bad

Governing a large state is like cooking a small fish. Let Tao prevail in the world, Even the spiritual beings lose their divine appeal. Not only they lose their appeal, Their a

Governing a great state, Is like cooking small fish. If you rule the world by Tao, The ghosts (kuei) will lose their spiritual (shen) power. Not that the ghosts lose their spiritual power, But their spiritua

er does not harm people. Not that their power does not harm people, but the Sage does not harm people. If neither does harm, Then Te flows and returns. up

e people take no harm from them; And if the spirits cannot hurt the folk, The Wise Man surely does no hurt to them. Since then the Wise Man and the people Harm each other not at all, Their several virtues should converge.

d cannot sway you. You realise that which is considered bad, may be good, and visa versa. Dropping ideas of good or bad, your actions are natural. up

ppeal harms no people. Not only their appeal harms no people, Neither the ruler harms people. Since both inflict no harm, Then all the benefits accrue jointly to the people. up

I power will not harm the people. Not that their spiritual power will not harm the people, But neither does the sage harm the people. Since both are harmless, Te flows back and forth [without impediment]. up

Chapter 61

A great nation
flows down To be
the world's pool,
The female under
heaven In stillness
The female
constantly
overcomes the
male, In stillness
Takes the low
place. Therefore a
great nation
Lowers itself And
wins over a small
one. A small
nation keeps itself
low And wins over

The great land is a
place To which the
streams descend;
It is the concourse
and The female of
the world:
Quiescent,
underneath, It
overcomes the
male. By quietness
and by humility
The great land
then puts down the
small And gets it
for its own; But
small lands too
absorb the great
By their
subservience.
Thus some lie l

A great master is
prepared for
nothing, so is
ready for
anything. He
trusts in the Tao
and accepts he
cannot control its
movement.
Realising its
greatness, he
serves it. Thus
he is humble

A big state is like
the downstream of
a river, where the
world converges,
and which
functions as the
female of the
world. The female
always overcomes
the male through
stillness. Stillness
means lying low.
Therefore, When a
big state places
itself below a small
state, It gains the
trust of the small
state; When a
small state places
itself below

A large state is
down stream (hsia
liu). Where the
rivers under
heaven (t'ien hsia)
converge, Is the
female (p'in) under
heaven. The
female always
wins the male
(mou) by stillness
(ching), By
stillness it is
low-lying (hsia).
Therefore, by
being low-lying
(hsia) to a small
state, A large state
acquires (ch'ü) a
small state. By
lowering (hsia)
itself to a large
state, A small state
acquires

a great one.
Sometimes
becoming low
wins, Sometimes
staying low wins. A
great nation
desires nothing
more Than to unite
and protect
people. A small
nation desires
nothing more Than
to enter the
service of people.
When both get
what they wish
The great one
should be low. up

ow, designing
conquest's ends;
While others lowly
are, by nature bent
To conquer all the
rest. The great
land's foremost
need is to increase
The number of its
folk; The small
land needs above
all else to find Its
folk more room to
work. That both be
served and each
attain its goal The
great land should
attempt humility.

and feminine.
Humble and
feminine, he
allows himself to
be nourished by
the Tao. Being
nourished by the
Tao, he himself
becomes great.
Greatness can
only be achieved
through humility.
up

a big state, It gains
the confidence of
the big state.
Thus: Sometimes
a state lies low in
order to gain,
Sometimes a state
lying low results in
gain. A big state
wishes only to
dominate and
lead, A small state
desires only to join
and follow. Now
that each of the
two gets what is
wants, It would still
be better for the
big state to lie low.
up

a large state. The
one acquires by
being low-lying
(hsia), The other
acquires by
lowering (hsia). A
large state without
overstepping its
boundary (pu kuo),
Wishes to keep
others under its
wings. A small
state without
overstepping its
boundary (pu kuo),
Wishes to offer
service to others.
Now both are
granted their
proper wishes, It is
fitting that a large
state takes the low
(hsia) place. up

Chapter 62

Tao is the mysterious center of all things, a treasure for those who are good, A refuge for those who are not. Beautiful words can be traded, Noble deeds can enhance reputations, But if people lack them, Why should they be rejected? When the Son of Heaven is enthroned And the

Like the gods of the shrine in the home, So the Way and its mystery waits In the world of material things: The good man's treasure, The bad man's refuge. Fair wordage is ever for sale; Fair manners are worn like a cloak; But why should there be such waste Of the badness in men? On the day of the emperor's crowning, When the t

Everything springs from the Tao. It shelters both the good and the bad. Men may try to succeed through their words and actions, but they are of benefit only if they lead to the Tao. There is little value in travelling a lifetime gathering weal

Tao holds secrets of all things. It is the treasure for good people, and The protector for bad people. Fine talks can earn one respect, Good deeds can elevate one's status. Then for those who have behaved badly, why abandon them? Thus: When crowning a king or installing three

To all beings Tao is the hidden secret (ao): To the good persons it is their treasure (pao), To the not good it is that by which they are preserved (pao). Beautiful speech can go to the market. Respectable conduct can be bestowed on others. Those who are not good, Why discard them? Therefore on crowning the Son of Heaven, On appointing the

Three Ministers installed, Presenting jade discs And four-horse chariots Cannot compare to sitting still And offering the Tao. The ancients honoured this Tao. Didn't they say: Through it seekers find, Through it the guilty escape? This is why Tao is honoured under Heaven. up

Three noble dukes are appointed, Better than chaplets of jade Drawn by a team of four horses, Bring the Way as your tribute. How used the ancients to honor the Way? Didn't they say that the seeker may find it, And that sinners who find are forgiven? So did they lift up the Way and its Virtue Above everything else in the world.

th. Ultimately value can only be found in the Tao. Why did the ancient masters value the Tao so highly? Because with the Tao, what you need, you get. Acting in accord with the Tao you are infallible. That is why its value is beyond measure. up

ministers, In spite of their beautiful jade offerings preceded by fast horses, It would be better to offer them Tao. What made the ancients value Tao? Did they not believe that: You would get what you seek and be forgiven of your sins? Therefore, it is valued by the world. up

Three Ducal Ministers (kung), Although there are tributes of jade, Preceding teams of four horses, It is better to kneel (tso) and present this Tao. Why did the ancients honor this Tao? One does not say that they did it for the purpose of gain, Rather they wish to be free from offenses (tsui). Therefore they were the honored under heaven. up

Chapter 63

Act without acting.
Serve without
serving. Taste
without tasting.
Big, little, Many,
few, Repay hatred
with Te. Map
difficult with easy
Approach great
through narrow.
The most difficult
things in the world
Must be
accomplished
through the
easiest. The
greatest things in
the wor

Act in repose; Be
at rest when you
work; Relish
unflavored things.
Great or small,
Frequent or rare,
Requite anger with
virtue. Take hard
jobs in hand While
they are easy; And
great affairs too
While they are
small. The troubles
of the world
Cannot be solved
except Before they
grow too hard. The
business of the
world Cannot be

Act without
expecting results.
Let the Tao do
your work. Taste
without tasting.
Look at the big as
small; think of the
many as few.
Have compassion
for petty tyrants.
Deal with things
when they arise.
Complete great
works by gradually
fulfilling them. To
become a master
of the Tao, take
one step at a time.
When yo

Take no willful
action, Diffuse
contentious even
to nonevent,
Transform the
tasteless tasteful.
Big or small,
numerous or few,
Repay enmities
with virtue.
Anticipate
difficulties while it
is still easy,
Prepare for being
big while it is still
small. Difficult
problems in the
world must have
grown from what
used to be easy,

Do (wei) when
there is nothing to
do (wu-wei),
Manage affairs
(shih) when there
are none to
manage, Know
(chih) by not
knowing. Regard
the great as small,
the much as little.
Repay injury
(yüan) with te.
Plan the difficult
while it is easy.
Accomplish (wei)
the great when it is
small. Difficult
affairs of the world,
Must be done
while they are
easy

Id Must be
accomplished
through the
smallest.
Therefore the
Sage Never
attempts great
things and so
accomplishes
them. Quick
promises Mean
little trust.
Everything easy
Means great
difficulty. Thus for
the Sage
everything is
difficult, And so in
the end Nothing is
difficult. up

done except While
relatively small.
The Wise Man,
then, throughout
his life Does
nothing great and
yet achieves A
greatness of his
own. Again, a
promise lightly
made Inspires little
confidence; Or
often trivial, sure
that man Will often
come to grief.
Choosing
hardship, then, the
Wise Man Never
meets with
hardship all his
life.

ur foothold is firm,
the next step will
come naturally.
The master never
aspires to
greatness, but is
immersed in every
step. This is his
greatness.
Promises can be
broken. What is
easy can become
difficult. The
master realises he
must ground his
step before he can
take another. For
this reason, he
never falls. up

Great events in the
world must have
started from what
used to be small.\
So the sage does
not aim to be
great, Thus he can
achieve greatness.
Light promises
often result in loss
of credibility, Easy
encounters often
are followed by
difficulties. So
even the sage
anticipates
difficulty, Thus he
encounters no
difficulty. up

. Great affairs of
the world, Must be
done while they
are small. The
sage never does
anything great,
Therefore he can
accomplish the
great. He who
makes promises
lightly seldom
keeps his words.
He who takes
much to be easy
finds much to be
difficult. Therefore
even the sage
takes things to be
difficult, So that in
the end they are
not difficult. up

Chapter 64

At rest is easy to
hold. Not yet
impossible is easy
to plan. Brittle is
easy to break.
Fine is easy to
scatter. Create
before it exists.
Lead before it
goes astray. A tree
too big to embrace
Is born from a
slender shoot. A
nine-story rises
from a pile of
earth. A
thousand-mile
journey Begins
with a single step.
Act and you ruin it.
Grasp and you
lose it. Therefore
the Sage Does

not act And so
does not ruin Does
not grasp And so
does not lose.
People commonly
ruin their work
When they are
near success.
Proceed at the end
as at the beginning
And your work
won't be ruined.
Therefore the
Sage Desires no
desires Prizes no
prizes Studies no
studies And
returns To what
others pass by.
The Sage Helps all
beings find their
nature, But does
not presume to
act. up

Chapter 65

Taoist rulers of old Did not enlighten people But left them dull. People are difficult to govern Because they are very clever. Therefore, Ruling through cleverness leads to rebellion. Not leading through cleverness Brings good

Those ancients who were skilled in the Way Did not enlighten people by their rule But had them ever held in ignorance: The more the folk know what is going on The harder it becomes to govern them. For public knowledge of the government Is such a thief that it will spoil the realm; But when good fortune brings good times to all

A master doesn't teach, but shows his disciples that what they think they know, they don't. If a person thinks they know, they are trapped in that knowledge. Once the master shows them not-knowing, they can guide themselves. A

Ancient rulers who were good at practicing Tao, Did not aim to enlighten the people, but to keep them ignorant. The difficulty in governing the people is due to their excessive knowledge. Therefore: He who governs a state through knowledge is the robber of the state; He who governs a state not through kno

Those in the past who were good at practicing Tao, Did not want to enlighten (ming) the people, But to keep them in ignorance (yü). People are hard to rule, Because they know (chih) too much. Therefore, to rule a nation by knowledge, Is to be the nation's thief. Not to rule a nation b

d fortune. Know these two things And understanding the enduring pattern. Understand the enduring pattern: This is called original Te. Original Te goes deep and far. All things reverse Return And reach the great headwaters. up

The land is ruled without publicity. To know the difference between these two Involves a standard to be sought and found. To know that standard always, everywhere, Is mystic Virtue, justly known as such; Which Virtue is so deep and reaching far, It causes a return, things go back To that prime concord which at first all shared.

t this stage the master's task is completed. The master doesn't try to show his prowess, but lets his disciples discover theirs. Therefore his disciples never resent him and simple allow him to point out their true essence. up

wledge is the blessing of the state. He who knows these two alternatives also values the model of Tao. Always valuing the model of Tao constitutes a profound virtue. The virtue is so profound and so far-reaching, Until the model becomes contrary to the reality! Only then the great harmony would prevail. up

y knowledge, Is to be the nation's blessing. To know these two is to know heaven's rule (chi shih). Always knowing heaven's rule, Is called the dark (hsüan) te. The dark te clarifies (ch'ing) and is far away (yüan). It reverts (fan) with things. Then there arrives the great harmony. up

Chapter 66

Rivers and seas
Can rule the
hundred valleys
Because they
are good at lying
low They are
lords of the
valleys.
Therefore those
who would be
above Must
speak as if they
are below Those
who would lead
Must speak as if
they are behind.

How could the
rivers and the seas
Become like kings
to valleys?
Because of skill in
lowliness They
have become the
valley's lords. So
then to be above
the folk, You
speak as if you
were beneath; And
if you wish to be
out front, Then act
as if you were
behind.

The ocean is the
destination of all
rivers. Why?
Because it is
placed below
them. This
shows the value
of humility. A
father, who
parents his
children with
humility, fo

Why the large river
or sea is able to be
the king of
hundred valley
streams? Because
it lies well below
them. Therefore it
becomes their
king. It follow that:
He who governs
the people must
declare that he is
to serve them; He
who lead the
people must place
him

Rivers and seas
can be kings of the
hundred valleys,
Because they are
good at flowing
downwards (hsia).
Therefore they can
be kings of the
hundred valleys.
Thus if you desire
to be above the
people, Your
words must reach
down (hsia) to
them. If you desire
to lead the people,
Your person (sh

In this way the
Sage dwells
above And the
people are not
burdened. Dwells
in front And they
are not hindered.
Therefore the
whole world Is
delighted and
unwearied. Since
the Sage does
not contend No
one can contend
with the Sage. up

The Wise Man so
is up above But is
no burden to the
folk; His station is
ahead of them To
see they do not
come to harm. The
world will gladly
help along The
Wise Man and will
bear no grudge.
Since he contends
not for his own
The world will not
contend with him.

llows them. By
following them
they will never
feel oppressed
and can develop
naturally. His
humility allows
them to express
themselves fully.
He is beyond
gratitude. up

self behind them.
So a wise ruler:
Stays above, the
people feel no
burden; Leads
ahead, the people
feel no threat.
Thus the world is
not tired of happily
supporting him.
Since he contends
against no one,
Therefore no one
in the world can
contend against
him. up

en, body) must be
behind them. Thus
the sage is above,
Yet the people do
not feel his weight.
He stays in front,
Yet the people do
not suffer any
harm. Thus all
gladly praise him
untiringly (pu yen).
Because he does
not contend with
any, Therefore no
one under heaven
can contend with
him. up

Chapter 67

Everyone under heaven calls my Tao great, and unlike anything else. It is great only because it is unlike anything else. If it were like anything else it would stretch and become thin. I have three treasures to maintain and conserve: the first is compassion. The second is frugality. The third is not presuming to be first under heaven. Compassion leads to co

Everywhere, they say the Way, our doctrine, is so very like detested folly; But greatness of its own alone explains why it should be thus held beyond the pale. If it were only orthodox, long since it would have seemed a small and petty thing! I have to keep three treasures well secured: The first, compassion; next, frugality; And third, I say that never would I once presume that I should be the whole world's chie

The Tao may appear to be idealistic, but if you can put it into practice, you realise its greatness. There are three traits which are required. 1. Compassion. 2. Patience. 3. Humility. Compassionate and you can face things the way they are.

The entire world says that my Tao is great, but it resembles not what is expected. Just because of its greatness, it resembles to what is expected. Otherwise, it would have become insignificant long ago. I have three treasures, keep and treasure them: The first is to love, The second is to conserve, and The third is dare not be the first in the world. Be able to conserve, then you can be courageous. Be

All under heaven say that my Tao is great, That it seems useless (pu hsiao). Because it is great, Therefore it seems useless. If it were useful, It would have long been small. I have three treasures (pao), To hold and to keep: The first is motherly love (tz'u), The second is frugality (chien), The third is daring not be at the world's front. With motherly love one can be courageous, With frugality on

urage. Frugality allows generosity. Not presuming to be first Creates a lasting instrument. Nowadays, People reject compassion But want to be brave, Reject frugality But want to be generous, Reject humility And want to come first. This is death. Compassion: Attack with it and win. Defend with it and stand firm. Heaven aids and protects Through compassion. up

Thus you can forgive yourself of any mistake. Patient and you remain unmoved until the right opportunity arises. Humble and you overcome self-importance, thus the ego. In following the Tao, these are your three most valuable treasures. up

able to conserve, then you can be generous. Dare not to be the first in the world, then you can be the leader. Now: To abandon love and be courageous, To abandon conservation and be generous, To abandon no be the first in the world and rush ahead. This is fatal! Because of love, you will be victorious in battle, and invincible in Defense! When Heaven is about to save you, it protects you with love. up

e can be wide reaching, Daring not be at the world's front, One can grow to a full vessel (ch'i). Now to discard motherly love, yet to be courageous, To discard frugality, yet to be wide reaching, To discard staying behind, yet to be at the front, One dies! One with motherly love is victorious in battle, Invulnerable in defense. When Heaven wills to save a people, It guards them with motherly love. up

Chapter 68

The accomplished person is not aggressive. The good soldier is not hot tempered. The best conqueror does not engage the enemy. The most effective leader t

A skillful soldier is not violent; An able fighter does not rage; A mighty conqueror does not give battle; A great commander is a humble man. Yo

The best warrior isn't intent on killing. The best sportsman isn't concerned about winning. The best tactician enters the mind of his opponent. A true businessman works for the goo

A good statesman does not rely on his military strength; A good fighter does not lose his temper; A good winner does not argue with his adversary; A good employer of talents

A good captain does not exhibit his martial prowess. A good warrior does not get himself angry. A good conqueror of enemies does not instigate a combat. A good employer of people pu

akes the lowest place. This is called the Te of not contending. This is called the power of the leader. This is called matching Heaven's ancient ideal. up

u may call this pacific virtue; Or say that it is mastery of men; Or that it is rising to the measure of God, Or to the stature of the ancients.

d of the community, not to rape them of their wealth and destroy the earth. A true leader has no agenda. Competition breeds violence. Peace can only be had by doing away with it. up

places himself below them. This is the virtue of no contention; This is the strength of managing talents; This is the adaptation to Heaven, The ultimate standard of old. up

ts himself below them. This is called the power (te) of non-contention. This is called using the strength of others. This is called perfection (chi) in matching the heaven of old. up

Chapter 69

There is a saying
in the army: I do
not presume to
be the master,
But become the
guest. I do not
dare advance an
inch, but retreat
a foot. This is
called moving
without moving,
rolling up sleeves
without showing
your arms,
Repell

The strategists
have a saying: "If
I cannot be host,
Then let me be
guest. But if I
dare not advance
Even an inch,
Then let me
retire a foot."
This is what they
call A campaign
without a march,
Sleeves up

There is a
saying:"It is
sometimes better
to wait and see
than to act first. It
is safer to retreat a
foot, than to
advance and inch."
Following this
saying, energy is
conserved. When
the correct course
of action becomes
apparent, you are
able to act. In
trying to overcome
the ego, it can't be
defeated directly.
Don'

The military
strategist says: I
dare not be an
aggressor, but a
defender; I dare
not advance an
inch, but to
retreat a foot.
This implies that
we: March
without
formation; Raise
no arms; Face
enemies
undetected; and
Ho

In engaging in
warfare it is said: I
dare not be the
host but be the
guest, I dare not
advance an inch
but retreat a foot.
This is called to
march without
advancing, To roll
up one's sleeves
without baring
one's arms, To
throw a rope
without an enemy,

ing without
opposing,
Wielding without
a weapon. There
is no disaster
greater than
Contempt for the
enemy.
Contempt for the
enemy - what a
treasure is lost!
Therefore, When
the fighting gets
hot, Those who
grieve will
conquer. up

but no bare
arms, Shooting
but no enemies,
Or arming
without weapons.
Than helpless
enemies, nothing
is worse: To
them I lose my
treasures. When
opposing
enemies meet,
The
compassionate
man is the
winner!

t see it as bad, and
there will be no
conflict in you. If
you create conflict,
your three
treasures will be
lost, and you will
become an enemy
to yourself. To
overcome the ego,
yield to it, and
simply be aware of
its motivations.
Once its
motivations are
apparent, it is
discredited and will
lose all power over
you. up

ld hidden
weapons. There
is no greater
danger than
underestimating
the enemy,
Underestimating
the enemy nearly
destroys my
treasures.
Therefore: When
to armies of
equal strength go
to battle, The
aggrieved side
wins. up

To carry without a
weapon. Of all
calamities (huo),
None is greater
than
underestimating
one's enemy. In
underestimating
my enemy, I risk
losing my treasure
(pao). Therefore
when opposing
armies are
engaged in battle,
The sorrowful
party will win. up

Chapter 70

My words are
very easy to
understand, Very
easy to practice.
No one under
heaven can
understand
them, No one
can practice
them. Words
have ancestors,
Deeds have
masters

My words are
easy just to
understand: To
live by them is
very easy too;
Yet it appears
that none in all
the world Can
understand or
make them come
to life. My words
have ancestors,
my wo

The way of the
master is simple,
and easy to
practice. But
your mind cannot
understand, and
you can't try to
attain it. Ordinary
people are
interested in the
mundane world,
and even if they
hear of the Tao
they don't grasp
its

My teachings are
very easy to
understand and
very easy to
practice. But the
world cannot
understand
them, nor
practice them.
There are:
Principles in my
teachings, and
Philosophy
governing my
undert

My words (yen)
are very easy to
understand
(i-chih), Very easy
to put into practice
(i-hsing). But no
one under heaven
can understand
(chih) them, No
one can put them
into practice.
Words (yen) have
their ruler (chün);
Events (shih) have
their progenitor
(tsu)

. If people don't
understand this,
They don't
understand me.
Few understand
me, And that is
my value.
Therefore the
Sage wears
rough clothing
And carries Jade
inside. up

rks a prince;
Since none know
this, unknown I
too remain. But
honor comes to
me when least
I'm known: The
Wise Man, with a
jewel in his
breast, Goes
clad in garments
made of shoddy
stuff.

depth. Few and
far between are
those who follow
the way. They
realise those
who don't follow,
aren't ready, so
don't try to
persuade them.
Those who
become ready
have to lose all
hope. Once all
hope is lost,
there is hope. up

akings. Simply
because of
ignorance,
people do not
understand me.
Those who do
are few, those
who practice my
teachings are
rare. Thus the
sage is clothed in
rags but hides a
precious jade
inside. up

ng). Because
people do not
understand (chih)
this, Therefore
they do not
understand me.
Those who
understand me are
rare, Those who
follow (tsê) my
teaching are
(preciously) few
(kuei). Therefore
the sage wears
hair-cloth, While
carrying jade in his
breast. up

Chapter 71

Know
not-knowing:
supreme. Not
know knowing:
faulty Only
faulting faults is
fa

To know that you
are ignorant is
best; To know
what you do not,
is a disease; But
if you recognize
the malady Of
mind for what it is

You can only
know when there
is no knowing.
Thinking you
know is a
delusion. If you
realise the
delusion is your
o

Knowing what
you do not know
is the best,
Pretending to
know what you
do not know is a
disease. Only be
treating the
disease as a
disease

From knowing to
not knowing
(chih, pu chih),
This is superior.
From not
knowing to
knowing (pu
chih, chih), This
is sickness. It is

ultless. The Sage
is faultless By
faulting faults,
And so is without
fault. up

, then that is
health. The Wise
Man has indeed
a healthy mind;
He sees an
aberration as it is
And for that
reason never will
be ill.

wn, it can be
cleared. The
master has
rejected all
knowing, and his
delusion has
cleared. He is
now enlightened.
up

, Can one be free
from it. The sage
is free from the
disease Because
he treats the
disease as a
disease,
Therefore he is
free from it. up

by being sick of
sickness, That
one is not sick.
The sage is not
sick. Because he
is sick of
sickness,
Therefore he is
not sick. up

Chapter 72

When people are not in awe of power, Power becomes great. Do not intrude into their homes, Do not make their lives weary. If you do not weary them, They wi

If people do not dread your majesty, A greater dread will yet descend on them. See then you do not cramp their dwelling place, Or immolate their children or their stock, Nor anger them

The master's sense of wonder is constant, like a déjà vu that never ends. He realises this wonder is missing from others, but leaves them be unless they ask f

When the people are no longer afraid of the power of authority, Then the awesome power of authority descends with a vengeance. Do not disturb the people in their habitats, Do not choke off their means of livelihood. Only by not

When the people fear no power, Then great power has indeed arrived. Do not disturb them in their dwellings, Do not weary them in their living. It is because you do not weary (pu yen) them, That they are not

Il not becoem weary of you. Therefore the Sage Has self-knowledge without self-display, Self-love without personal pride, Rejects one, accepts the other. up

by your own angry ways. It is the Wise Man's way to know himself, And never to reveal his inward thoughts; He loves himself but so, is not set up; He chooses this in preference to that.

or help. Having no self, he understands them. If he would push or prod, they would distance themselves. He has let go of the idea that people can be helped. up

being oppressive, will people feel not oppressed. Therefore a wise ruler: Knows his authority, but does not show of his power, Values self-respect, but does not exalt his position. Thus he chooses this and rejects the other. up

wearied of you. Therefore the sage knows himself (tzu chih), But does not see himself (tzu chien). He loves himself (tzu ai), But does not exalt himself (tzu kuei). Therefore he leaves that and takes this. up

Chapter 73

Courage to dare kills, Courage not to dare saves. One brings profit, one brings harm. Of these two, one is good, and one is harmful. Some are not favored by heaven. Who knows why? Even the wise consider it a difficult question. Heaven hates what it hates - W

A brave man who dares to, will kill; A brave man who dares not, spares life; And from them both come good and ill; "God hates some folks, but who knows why?" The Wise Man hesitates there too: God's Way is bound to conqu

Acting passionately can lead to trouble. Being indifferent, there is no trouble. The reasons why things happen can hardly be known, so we can't know if something is good or bad. By not trying to succeed, every

To be brave in daring results in a killing; To be brave in not daring results in life. Of the two, one is beneficial, the other harmful. Whatever Heaven disfavours, Who knows the reason? (Thus even the sage considers this a diffi

One who is courageous out of daring (kan) is killed. One who is courageous out of not daring lives. Of these two, this is beneficial while that is harmful. What heaven hates, who knows the reason? Therefore even the sage takes it to be difficult. The way of heaven: W

ho knows why! Even the Sage finds it difficult. Heaven's Tao does not contend But prevails, Does not speak, But responds, Is not summoned, But arrives, Is utterly still, But plans all actions. Heaven's net is wide, wide, Loose - But nothing slips through. up

er all But not by strife does it proceed. Not by words does God get answers: He calls them not and all things come. Master plans unfold but slowly, Like God's wide net enclosing all: Its mesh is coarse but none are lost.

thing is successful. Without speaking, everything is said. By not seeking, it can be found. The natural way covers everything and every event like a net. Though its meshes may be wide, nothing slips through. up

cult question.) The way of heaven is good at: Winning without striving; Responding without announcing; Forthcoming without prompting; and Planing without haste. The net of Heaven is extremely vast, It is coarse but not leaking. up

ithout contending (cheng), it is yet good at winning, Without speaking, it is yet good in responding, Without being beckoned, it yet comes of its own accord, Unhurried, it is yet good at planning (mou). The net of heaven is vast, Widely spaced, yet missing nothing. up

Chapter 74

If people do not fear death, How dare you threaten them with death? But if people with a normal fear of death Are about to do something vicious, And I could seize and execute them, W

The people do not fear at all to die; What's gained therefore by threatening them with death? If you could always make them fear de cease, As if it were a strange event and rare, Who then would dare to take and s

Death is a natural part of life, and it is your fate. If you accept this fully, there is no fear. Having no fear, your actions are powerful. If you try to manage your

When the people are not afraid to die Why then threaten them with death? Even if they normally are fearful of death, For worst offenders, we may seize and kill them. But who dares to execute? There is always an e

The people do not fear death, Why threaten them with death? Suppose the people always fear death, One who does strange things (ch'i), I shall seize and kill, Then who dares [to do strange things]? Killing is car

ho would dare? There is always an official executioner. Trying to take the executioner's place, Is like trying to replace a master woodworker - Few would not slice their own hands. up

laughter them? The executioner is always set To slay, but those who substitute for him Are like would-be master carpenters Who try to chop as that skilled craftsman does And nearly always mangle their own hands!

life, you won't live. Because of death there is no risk, hence nothing to manage. A life based on death will be fulfilling. A life based on life will lead to death. up

xpert executioner who kills. Substituting for an expert executioner, Is like hacking wood in place of a master carpenter. Whoever substitutes for the master carpenter, He seldom escapes injury of his own hand. up

ried out by the executioner. To replace the executioner and kill, Is like chopping wood in place of the master carpenter. To chop wood in place of the master carpenter, Rarely one does not hurt one's own hand. up

Chapter 75

People are hungry. When rulers tax grain People are hungry. People are rebellious. When rulers are active People are rebellious. People

The people starve because of those Above them, who consume by tax In grain and kind more than their right. For this, the people are in want. The people are so hard to rule Because of those who are above them, Whose interference makes dist

If you require many concessions from children, they won't be able to fulfil their own hearts. Give them many rules to follow and the

The people are hungry, because Their ruler consumes too much of their tax grains. That is why they are hungry. The people become difficult to govern, because Their ruler takes willful actions, That is why they are dif

People are hungry. Because their rulers levy too much grain tax, Therefore they are hungry. People are hard to rule. Because their rulers rule by action (wei), Therefore they are hard to

ignore death. When searching only for life's bounty People ignore death. Only those who do not strive after life Truly respect life. up

ress. For this, they are so hard to rule. The people do not fear to die; They too demand to live secure: For this, they do not fear to die. So they, without the means to live, In virtue rise above those men Who value life above its worth.

y will rebel. When people outwardly value life, death is taken lightly. If death is taken lightly, life will easily be sacrificed. up

ficult to govern. The people take death lightly, because Their ruler demands too much for his luxurious life. That is why they take death lightly. Only he who does not overvalue his own life excels in valuing life. up

rule. People take death lightly. Because they are in thick pursuit of life, Therefore they take death lightly. One who has nothing to pursue in life, Is wiser than one who values life. up

Chapter 76

Humans are born soft and weak. They die stiff and strong. The ten thousand plants and trees Are born soft tender, And die withered and sere. The stiff and strong Are Death's companion

Alive, a man is supple, soft; In death, unbending, rigorous. All creatures, grass and trees, alive Are plastic but are pliant too, And dead, are friable and dry. Unbending rigor is the mate of death, And

When a baby is born, it is soft and flexible. When a man dies he is static and stiff. A living plant bends and flowers. Dead, it is brittle and barren. Stiff and static, you are as

A human body is weak and pliable at birth, and is stiff and hard at death. Grass and trees are tender and soft at birth, and are dry and brittle at death. Therefore, The hard and strong belong to the company of death; The soft and w

At birth a person is soft (jou) and yielding (jo), At death hard (chien) and unyielding (ch'iang). All beings, grass and trees, when alive, are soft and bending, When dead they are dry and brittle. Therefore the hard and unyielding are compan

s The soft and weak Are Life's companions. Therefore the strongest armies do not conquer, The greatest trees are cut down. The strong and great sink down. The soft and weak rise up. up

wielding softness, company of life: Unbending soldiers get no victories; The stiffest tree is readiest for the ax. The strong and mighty topple from their place; The soft and yielding rise above them all.

if dead. Flexible and soft, you are a beacon of life. That which is stiff and brittle will easily snap, and be destroyed. That which is soft and flexible will bend, and endure. up

weak belong to the company of life. It follows then: A strong army is destined to be destroyed; A hard wood tree is doomed to be broken. The hard and strong are in an inferior position, The soft and weak are in a superior position. up

ions of death, The soft and yielding are companions of life. Hence an unyielding army (ping) is destroyed (mieh). An unyielding tree breaks (che). The unyielding and great takes its place below, The soft and yielding takes its place above. up

Chapter 77

Heaven's Tao Is
a stretched bow,
Pulling down on
the top Pulling up
on the bottom. If
it's too much, cut.
If it's not enough,
Add on to it:
Heaven's Tao.
The Human
Route Is not like
this, Depriving
the poor,

Is not God's Way
much like a bow
well bent? The
upper part has
been disturbed,
pressed down;
The lower part is
raised up from its
place; The slack is
taken up; the
slender width Is
broader drawn; for
thus the Way of
God Cuts people
down when they
have had too
much, And fills the
bowls of those
who are in want.
But not the way of
man wil

The Tao
functions like a
bending bow.
When something
is gained,
something else is
lost. If there is
excess here,
there will be
deficiency there.
A rich man, who
takes more from
those who are
lacking

Is Heaven's way
like aiming an
extended bow? If
aiming too high,
lower it; If aiming
too high, raise it.
Thus, The surplus
is reduced and the
needy
supplemented.
The way of
Heaven is to
reduce the surplus
so as to
supplement the
needy. The way of
Mankind is just the
op

The way of
heaven, Is it not
like stretching a
bow? What is high
up is pressed
down, What is low
down is lifted up;
What has surplus
(yu yü) is reduced,
What is deficient
(pu tsu) is
supplemented.
The way of
heaven, It reduces
those who have
surpluses, To
supplement those
who are deficient.
The human way

Offering to the
rich. Who has a
surplus And still
offers it to the
world? Only
those with Tao.
Therefore the
Sage Acts and
expects nothing,
Accomplishes
and does not
linger, Has no
desire to seem
worthy. up

I work like this:
The people who
have not enough
are spoiled For
tribute to the rich
and surfeited. Who
can benefit the
world From stored
abundance of his
own? He alone
who has the Way,
The Wise Man
who can act apart
And not depend on
others' whims; But
not because of his
high rank Will he
succeed; he does
not wish To flaunt
superiority.

, will become
deficient in the
Tao. The master
gives, therefore
he has. He
doesn't need
recognition and
acts with no
thought of
reward. With no
thought of
reward,
everything he
does is
rewarding. up

posite: It takes
away from the
needy so as to
enrich the surplus.
Who would offer
their surpluses to
the world? Only
followers of Tao.
So the sage it to:
Care for but not to
master; Complete
the work without
claiming credit;
and Avoid
recognition of his
achievements. up

is just not so. It
reduces those who
are deficient, To
offer those who
have surpluses.
Who can offer his
surpluses to the
world? Only a
person of Tao.
Therefore the sage
works (wei)
without holding on
to, Accomplishes
without claiming
credit. Is it not
because he does
not want to show
off his merits? up

Chapter 78

Nothing in the world is soft and weak as water. But when attacking the hard and strong Nothing can conquer so easily. Weak overcomes strong, soft overcomes hard. Everyone knows this, no one attains it.

Nothing is weaker than water, But when it attacks something hard Or resistant, then nothing withstands it, And nothing will alter its way. Everyone knows this, that weakness prevails Over strength and that gentleness conquers The adamant hindrance of

Water is the softest thing in the world. But in dissolving things that are hard, nothing can better it. This is because it can't be broken, thus it endures. Everybody knows the soft is stronger than

Nothing in the world is softer and weaker than water. Yet there is nothing better for conquering the hard and strong, and there is no substitute for it. That the weak overcomes the strong and The soft overcomes the hard, Is understood by the

Nothing under heaven Is softer (jou) and weaker (jo) than water, Yet nothing can compare with it In attacking the hard (chien) and strong (ch'iang). Nothing can change (i) place with it. That the weak overcomes the strong, And the soft overcomes the hard, No one under heaven does not know (ch

ins it. Therefore the Sage says: Accept a country's filth And become master of its sacred soil. Accepts country's ill fortune And become king under heaven. True words resemble their opposites. up

men, but that Nobody demonstrates how it is so. Because of this the Wise Man says That only one who bears the nations shame Is fit to be its hallowed lord; That only one who takes upon himself The evils of the world may be its king. This is paradox.

n the hard, and the passive overcomes the aggressive, but few put this into practice. The master is humble, therefore he is great. Because he can follow, he is able to lead. Truth is paradoxical. up

entire world, But non can practice it. So the sage says: One who suffers disgrace for the state is qualified to be its leader. One who carries the burden of the state's misfortune is fit to be its king. The words of truth sound contrarian. up

ih), Though none can put it into practice. Therefore a sage said: "One who receives the filth of a state, Is called the Master of the Altar of the Soil and Grain; One who shoulders the evils of a state, Becomes the king under heaven." Straightforward words (yen) appear to be their reverse. up

Chapter 79

Appears great
hatred and
hatred will
remain. How can
this be good?
Therefore the
Sage Holds the
tally But does not
judge people.

How can you
think it is good
To settle a
grievance too
great To ignore,
when the
settlement Surely
evokes other
piques? The
Wise Man
therefore will
select The
left-hand part of
contract t

Behind every
failure, is a
success. If you
blame, you will
be blamed. The
master takes
responsibility for
himself and is
not concerned
with the ac

Deep grievances
can be
ameliorated, but
residual ones
remain. How can
this situation be
improved? Thus:
The sage holds
the left half of the
debt instrument,
and never
abuses the

In reconciling a
great injury
(yüan), There is
sure to have
some injury left.
How can this be
good? Therefore
the sage holds
the left tally, He
does not blame
others. On

Those who have
Te Control the
tally. Those who
lack Te Collect
their due.
Heaven has no
favourites But
endures in good
people. up

allies: He will not
put the debt on
other men. This
virtuous man
promotes
agreement; The
vicious man
allots the blame.
"Impartial though
the Way of God
may be, It always
favors good
men."

tions of others.
He expects
nothing from
them, and
doesn't rely on
them. If a
mistake is made
he accepts it.
Through this he
avoids
disturbance. up

debtor. A person
of virtue just
keeps the left
portion; but A
person of no
virtue abuses the
debtor. The way
of Heaven is
neutral, But it
always sides with
the virtuous
person. up

e who has te is in
charge of the
tally, One who
has no te is in
charge of the tax
law. The Tao of
heaven has no
partiality (ch'in),
It is always with
the good people.
up

Chapter 80

Small country,
few people -
Hundreds of
devices, But
none are used.
People ponder
on death And
don't travel far.
They have
carriages and
boats, But no
one goes on
board; Weapons
and armour, But
no one
brandishes them.
They use knotted
cords f

The ideal land is
small Its people
very few, Where
tools abound Ten
times or yet A
hundred-fold
Beyond their use;
Where people die
And die again But
never emigrate;
Have boats and
carts Which no
one rides.
Weapons have
they And armor
too, But none
displayed. The folk
returns To use ag

When happy:
Even if you have
occult powers,
they will not be
used, You can
achieve great
works, but there
is no need, You
can travel far and
wide, but you
stay at home,
You can become
a great man, but
you remain unkn

There exists a
small state with a
few people.
Wherein: Plenty of
useful tools are not
being used.
Valuing life, the
people do not
migrate faraway.
Though there are
boats and
carriages, no one
rides in them. Let
the people return
to the time of tying
knots on ropes for
reckoning. Let
them: Enjoy

A small state with
few people. Let the
implements (ch'ih)
for ten and
hundred men be
unused, Let the
people fear death
such that they do
not move far away.
Although there are
boats and
carriages, There
are no places to
ride them to.
Although there are
weapons and
armours, There
are no occasions
to display them.
Let the people
again tie ropes a

or counting.
Sweet is their
food, Beautiful
their clothes,
Peaceful their
homes, Delightful
their customs.
Neighboring
countries are so
close You can
hear their
chickens and
dogs. But people
grow old and die
Without needing
to come and go.
up

ain The knotted
chords. Their meat
is sweet; Their
clothes adorned,
Their homes at
peace, Their
customs charm.
And neighbor
lands Are
juxtaposed So
each may hear
The barking dogs,
The crowing cocks
Across the way;
Where folks grow
old And folks will
die And never
once Exchange a
call.

own, You can
control people,
but you leave
them be. Joy is
found in ordinary
goings on. Even
though you may
be able to see
the border to the
next country, you
are content to die
of old age never
having been
there. up

their food, Beautify
their clothing, Live
in peace at home,
and Be happy with
their heritage. The
people in
neighbouring
states are within
sight of each
other, The crowing
of cocks and
barking of dogs
are heard from
each other, Yet the
people die of old
age without visiting
with each other. up

nd use them (as
memory aids). Let
them enjoy their
food, Consider
their clothing
beautiful, Be
contented with
their dwellings,
And happy with
their customs. The
neighbouring
states overlooking
one another, The
dogs' barkings and
cocks' crowings
are heard from
other states, Yet
till they are old and
dying the people
do not visit one
another. up

Chapter 81

Sincere words
and not pretty.
Pretty words are
not sincere.
Good people do
not quarrel.
Quarrelsome
people are not
good. The wise
are not learned.
The learned are
not wise. The

As honest words
may not sound
fine, Fine words
may not be
honest ones; A
good man does
not argue, and
An arguer may
not be good! The
knowers are not
learned men And
learned men may
never know. The
Wise Man does
not hoard his
things;

True words aren't
beautiful. Beautiful
words are not
truthful. The wise
do not argue.
Those who argue
are not wise.
Those who know
have no
knowledge. Those
with knowledge
don't know. The
master has
nothing, but gives
everything he has.
The more he
gives, the happier
he is. Only with t

Credible words
are not artful:
Artful words are
not credible. An
objective person
does not argue;
A person who
argues is not
objective. He
who knows the
truth may not be
erudite; He who
is erudite may
not know the
truth. The sage
does not

Truthful (hsin)
words (yen) are
not beautiful,
Beautiful (mei)
words are not
truthful. The good
(shan) does not
distinguish, One
who distinguishes
(pien) is not good.
One who knows
(chih) does not
accumulate
knowledge, One
who accumulates
knowledge (po)
does not know.
The s

Sage is not
acquisitive - Has
enough By doing
for others, Has
even more By
giving to others.
Heaven's Tao
Benefits and
does not harm.
The Sage's Tao
Acts and does
not contend.

Hard-pressed,
from serving
other men, He
has enough and
some to spare;
But having given
all he had, He
then is very rich
indeed. God's
Way is gain that
works no harm;
The Wise Man's
way, to do his
work Without
contending for a
crown.

he Tao can you be
fulfilled. The
beginning doesn't
exist; the end
doesn't exist,
except through the
other. Is finishing
verse eighty-one,
the end, or the
beginning? If you
think it is the end,
you need to read it
again. If you think
it is the beginning,
you also need to
read it again.

hoard for himself,
The more he
benefits others
the happier he
becomes, The
more he gives
away to others
the wealthier he
feels. The way of
Heaven; benefits
all, harms none.
The way of the
sage: be helpful
to all,
contentious
against none.

age does not
hoard. Having
worked (wei) for
his fellow beings,
The more he
possesses. Having
donated himself to
his fellow beings,
The more
abundant he
becomes. The way
of heaven, It
benefits (li), but
does not harm.
The way of the
sage, He works
(wei), but does not
contend.